Eleven Missing Days

By

Ernesto Foronda

Based on the book

Agatha Christie and the Eleven Missing Days

by Jared Cade

2/25/26 Draft

INT. CHRISTIE HOME / SURREY, ENGLAND - OFFICE - NIGHT

A BLANK PAGE IN A TYPE WRITER.

FRIDAY, DECEMBER 3, 1926.

AGATHA CHRISTIE let's out a cry of frustration. Near tears.

She gives up, opens her desk draw--

It's empty. Panic takes hold.

AGATHA
No. No no no...

Agatha rifles through drawers and cupboards searching for something, manic. *

Eventually, she collapses. Desperate. Hope lost. *

INT. BEDROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Agatha throws items in a suitcase; a cloche hat, zippered purse. She puts on a FUR COAT. *

INT. ROSALIND'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Agatha’s daughter, ROSALIND, is fast asleep. Agatha gives her an achingly gentle peck on her forehead, torn.

INT. STAIRCASE / HALLWAY - NIGHT

Agatha hastens down the hallway. THE BUTLER and HOUSEKEEPER scatter and hide. *

She places AN ENVELOPE on the console table before rushing out the door. The house staff cluster, concerned.

INT. CAR - NIGHT *

Agatha drives through fog down a dark road.

She rounds a bend at speed. HEADLIGHTS from an ONCOMING CAR blind her. Agatha shields her eyes.

EXT. ROAD - NIGHT

Agatha’s car veers off the road --

Towards a 100ft cliff. A tree stops the car's trajectory, moments from the edge. Smoke rises from the car’s engine.

INT. CAR - NIGHT

Agatha slowly comes to. She touches her head. Blood smears her fingers. *
*

A noise outside. She looks at the rearview mirror – sees a FIGURE IN SHADOW approaching.

CUT TO:

ELEVEN MISSING DAYS

TITLES PLAY OVER A SERIES OF CLOSE UPS:

- Camera BULBS BURN and DIE. HEELS on a red carpet.

- Agatha's smile is captured by a flash.

- Her husband, ARCHIBALD CHRISTIE, dashing, holds her hand.

- A PHOTOGRAPHER flaps his hand, mouths 'Now, with Charles!' Archie recedes into the shadows.

- A SMALL, PORTLY ACTOR with a ridiculous mustache steps next to Agatha. He beams. She smiles curtly.

CUT WIDE Agatha and the actor pose awkwardly beneath the marquee: *AGATHA CHRISTIE'S POIROT IN "**ALIBI**"*

WE END on the PHOTOGRAPH of Agatha, emotionless, still, enigmatic.

BASED ON TRUE EVENTS

EXT. SIDE ALLEY - EARLY MORNING

The sun is barely up. At the end of a grim alley, a pristine car pulls up.

SUPER: **ONE MISSING DAY**

A CHAUFFEUR opens the door for NAN WATTS, a prim-looking woman, too clean for this part of town. She checks door numbers and moves out of view. Loud knocking.

NAN (O.S.)
Detective Pieters?

No answer.

NAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Detective Pieters! Inspector Highsmith sent me--

A window opens somewhere.

WOMAN (O.S.)
Love, these walls are paper thin! If you're looking for the French fella, since he retired he's usually round back, tending the vegetables.

The woman laughs, as Nan peers into the alleyway.

A chute from the upstairs restaurant opens, a crate of rotten cabbages falls into the alley, just missing Nan.

BURLY MAN
(from above)
Wouldn’t stand there if I were you, love.

He disappears. Nan composes herself and walks forward, towards a slumped FIGURE sleeping on a heap of—rotting vegetables, an empty bottle of wine at his feet.

Nan covers her nose and pokes at the figure with her umbrella. MOTIONLESS. She pokes again. The figure SLAPS the umbrella away, startling her.

NAN
Detective Pieters?

HUGO PIETERS. Expressive features emerge from behind a scraggly, unkempt mustache and beard as he looks up to see Nan’s backlit figure.

HUGO
Teresa?

He shields his eyes from the light – sees Nan and struggles to his feet using his CANE.

HUGO (CONT'D)
I must have misplaced my keys.

His accent is vaguely French.

Nan taps her umbrella on the side door of his building -- his KEYS rest in the keyhole.

NAN
Do you mean these keys?

Pieters raises a brow, takes the keys, and pockets them.

HUGO
And you are..?

NAN
Nan Watts. Inspector Highsmith is a family friend, he suggested I come see you. It is an urgent matter.

Hugo reaches into his pocket, pulls out a carrot, and tosses it aside. He retrieves a pocket watch: Not even 8 AM!

HUGO
Maybe you should return at a more sensible hour. I should be more equipped to handle urgent matters then.

NAN
(taken aback)
My dearest friend has gone missing. God knows if she’s even alive,

Hugo's attention is drawn upwards.

HUGO
Madame...

NAN
...and I was told that you were the only one who could help! Inspector Highsmith was clearly mistaken.

HUGO
If I could just have one second...

NAN
And one last thing. You, sir, are no gentleman. Just an inexcusable drunk!

Just then, the chute swings open. Hugo reflexively moves back as Nan is showered by a pail full of ROTTEN VEGETABLES.

INT. DETECTIVE PIETERS' OFFICE - MORNING

A shell-shocked Nan sits in a cramped, untidy office, wiping herself with a towel. She scans various photos, citations, and awards around the room. A nearby table filled with empty wine bottles, UNPAID BILLS, and an EVICTION NOTICE.

INT. BATHROOM

Hugo cleans himself with a washcloth. He examines his reflection, then takes out a near-empty prescription bottle of morphine. Downs a SMALL CHALKY CUBE.

When he opens his eyes, a DARK-HAIRED WOMAN, TERESA, is reflected in the mirror behind him. She smiles and puts her hand on his shoulder. Hugo relaxes, accepting the memory.

INT. DETECTIVE PIETERS' OFFICE - DAY

Nan, impatient, rises to leave when --

HUGO (O.S.)
Apologies. I'm famished.

Hugo walks in, with an air of dreamy ease, balancing a tray of tea and hard-boiled eggs. He motions for Nan to eat. She politely declines.

Hugo pours his tea, then rummages through the bowl of eggs comparing them.

NAN
Her name is Agatha Christie, the novelist. You may have heard of her.

HUGO
(preoccupied)
I have very little time for reading, especially fiction.

Hugo holds up another pair of eggs. Finally, two identically sized eggs.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Voila!

Hugo peels then wolfs them down.

NAN
Please, Detective. Scotland Yard won't get involved. They say it's a matter for local police.

HUGO
I do murders, Madame. Not pulp-fictionists.

NAN
We'll pay well.

Pieters studies Nan with tired curiosity.

HUGO
When was she last seen?

NAN
Last night. Her car was found. Run off the road. Engine still warm.

HUGO
And you believe it’s foul play?

Nan barely nods.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Who is she?
(leaning in)
Not the name. The woman.

FLASH TO:

Agatha, eyes meeting ours squarely, unreadable.

BACK TO:

NAN
I don't see what that has to do with anything?

HUGO
Humor me.

NAN
She’s unlike anyone I’ve ever known.

FLASH TO:

Agatha casts her eyes downward.

NAN (V.O.)
She could be shy and incredibly private.

Agatha suddenly becomes enraged and shouts silently at us.

NAN (V.O.)
And yet she has a temper, my gosh -- *

Agatha turns again and laughs wildly.

NAN (V.O.)
But also this wild, adventurous spirit -- *

Agatha stops laughing and stares at us defiantly, proudly.

NAN (V.O.)
And then there's her ego, of course, she has quite the ego.

The corners of Agatha's mouth curl.

BACK TO PRESENT

NAN
But that often comes with brilliance, does it not?

HUGO
So she made enemies?

NAN
Not everyone understood Agatha.

Nan digs into her bag, pulls out a stack of Agatha's books.

NAN (CONT'D)
You'll want to start with Roger Ackroyd. She always said that one made men nervous.

Pieters glances at the pile.

NAN (CONT'D)
To know Agatha is to know her work.

Hugo absently flips through THE MURDER OF ROGER ACKROYD. He stops. A sentence underlined:

FLASH TO: *

Agatha, looking at us, determined, confident.

AGATHA
The truth, however ugly in itself, is always curious and beautiful to seekers after it.

BACK TO:

Hugo pauses. Familiar words, but he can't quite place them.

NAN
Inspector Highsmith assured me that, despite everything, you are still the best at what you do.

HUGO
I regret my answer must be--

Nan pulls out a thick ENVELOPE FILLED WITH CASH. Hugo's eyes flicker at the money --

HUGO (CONT'D)
I'll consider it.

EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - MORNING (PRESENT)

Hugo walks with a limp down a country road. He heads towards--

NAN (V.O.)
We need your help to find her, Detective.

EXT. NEWLANDS CORNER - MORNING

Above the dramatic cliffs POLICE keep a smattering of REPORTERS and ONLOOKERS away from Agatha's abandoned car.

Hugo makes his way through unfriendly glares from police with a BAG OF BAKED GOODS, his suit crumpled and ill-fitting. THE OFFICERS mutter in low tones but not out of earshot.

OFFICER ALTON
Oh, hello. The Prodigal Detective returns.

OFFICER BLAKE
Who?

They continue to gossip as Hugo moves towards Surrey Constable, WILLIAM KENWARD, distinguished, with sharp features, gathers and addresses a group of grumbling police officers --

KENWARD
Gentlemen, comb the area. If we do our jobs thoroughly, we should have the rest of our weekend undisturbed.

OFFICER #1
A little late for that, isn't it?!!

Laughter.

KENWARD
Settle down.
(beat)
I hear the team that first finds evidence leading to the missing author shall receive a reward.

The officers' ears perk.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
Possibly a week's salary.
Now let's get to...

Before he can finish, the officers scramble -- Everyone's gone except for Hugo, who crams the remaining pastry into his mouth.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
Sir, I must insist you make your way where the public is allowed to gawk from a safe distance.

HUGO
Constable Kenward? The very same who caught the Byfleet murderer?!

KENWARD
Why yes...

HUGO
I followed every riveting detail in the newspaper, as did the nation.

Jam falls from Hugo's pastry onto his jacket.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Merde.

Hugo wipes the jam with his hand, then wipes his hand on his pants before extending his hand.

HUGO.
I assure you, I'm Belgian, not French.

Kenward shakes his hand. Smells booze on his breath.

KENWARD
Thank you, but I really do need you to keep a distance. Nothing can be disturbed.

HUGO
But of course.

Kenward circles Agatha’s car, leans in for a closer look.

HUGO (CONT'D)
It’s a fine car, isn’t it?

Kenward startles. Hugo peers over his shoulder, way too close.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Apologies. I failed to introduce myself. Hugo Pieters. Madame Christie's family requested my presence to see if my services would be of help. It may not even be necessary; you and your men seem to have everything under control.

KENWARD
While I appreciate your *assistance*, until I hear from the Christie family --

HUGO
It's as if I am not here.
(beat, then)
The car did not roll off the cliff.

KENWARD
She was incredibly lucky.

HUGO
And yet the hand brake is pulled.

Kenward looks, seeing this for the first time. *

HUGO (CONT'D)
I see you've recovered a few items.

Hugo refers to the items on the passenger seat -- a dressing case, an elegant CLOCHE HAT, and a DRIVER’S LICENSE.

KENWARD
Everything but the fur coat on her back.

Hugo focuses on the license. *

HUGO *
No purse? *

KENWARD *
Not that we could find. *

HUGO *
I would expect a license to be *
tucked into a purse -- but perhaps *
she had little occasion to carry it *
since she rarely drove. *

Kenward looks at Hugo.

KENWARD
And how would you know that?

HUGO
The license has expired. For months now...

Kenward takes a close look at the license.

HUGO (CONT'D)
I'm sure you have taken all this into account.

Hugo is following the car's tracks towards the road, staggering a little with his cane.

Kenward watches Hugo animatedly, making gestures, inspecting the trajectory, grumbling to himself.

Hugo takes a step - CRACK! Something underfoot. He digs into the dirt and pulls out a shard of glass. Kenward approaches.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Seems like part of a headlight.

KENWARD
Obviously from Mrs. Christie's car.

HUGO
No, her headlights are whole.

KENWARD
Yes... of course.

HUGO
Probably from another car and of no consequence.

Hugo hands the glass to Kenward, who looks at it then pockets * it fastidiously. *

KENWARD
I really must ask that you wait on the road. *

HUGO
Tres bien. I was just leaving.

KENWARD
I'll escort you.

They walk towards the road. *

HUGO
Do you know much of Mrs. Christie?

KENWARD
As much as anyone. I've only read a few of her books, but that's more than enough. What does a woman know about solving crimes?

HUGO
Yet, she's quite the success.

KENWARD
I suppose one can't rely on people's taste.

HUGO
Never. Though I imagine this field will be quite the circus once the story is published.

KENWARD
I doubt anyone will be that interested.

And just then, a police car peels away to reveal an onslaught of REPORTERS and PHOTOGRAPHERS rushing towards them, shouting at the top of their lungs, cameras flashing.

HUGO
Et voila, and the best thing about *
the circus..?! *
(arching his brow) *
The performers!! *

Hugo chuckles to himself. Kenward doesn't find it the least bit humorous.

EXT. LONDON STREET - NIGHT

Hugo crosses the street towards a pub and notices a dark car parked up. The DRIVER sees Hugo and quickly unfolds a newspaper to hide his face.

Hugo buys the evening edition from a BOY on the corner. At the bottom of the front page is a small blurb on AGATHA CHRISTIE'S MYSTERIOUS DISAPPEARANCE.

Hugo tucks the paper under his arm, and heads into --

INT. STAG'S HEAD PUB - NIGHT

Hugo sits at the bar, his pocket-watch between his fingers as he orders a pint. Inscribed on the front cover: *Pour l'éternité* (FOR ETERNITY). He opens the pocket watch -- a picture of the beautiful DARK-HAIRED WOMAN, his wife, Teresa.

He's served his pint, which he quickly downs.

MAN (O.S.)
Another drink for my friend.

Hugo turns to find CHIEF INSPECTOR HIGHSMITH, the large and imposing head of Scotland Yard.

HIGHSMITH
You're looking well...

Hugo smiles between gritted teeth, not believing a word.

The bartender sets another pint in front of Hugo next to his copy of Agatha Christie's 'POIROT INVESTIGATES'.

HIGHSMITH (CONT'D)
(to the bartender)
Orange cordial please.
(to Hugo)
Good book?

HUGO
Haven't started it. Do I take it you are responsible for all this?

HIGHSMITH
I apologize for sending her to your home so early in the morning. She was knocking on my door at the crack of dawn, and it was all I could do to get her to leave.

HUGO
I haven’t decided to take the case.

HIGHSMITH
Take the case?! I never imagined that you would. I know it’s only been a few weeks since your suspension, surely it’s too early to take on a case.

HUGO
Much too early.

HIGHSMITH
Although one might argue that a high-profile case like this could put a positive light on your review...

HUGO
Yes, one might argue...

HIGHSMITH
But you have your health to think about. You should take things nice and slow. Recuperate.

Hugo swigs his beer.

HIGHSMITH (CONT'D)
For now, get more rest. Do some reading, maybe take up a hobby...

Highsmith is laying it on a bit thick. Hugo rises.

HIGHSMITH (CONT'D)
Pieters...

Hugo finishes the pint, wipes his mouth and takes the book.

HUGO
I have some reading to do.

Highsmith watches as Hugo leaves the pub. He picks up his cordial and sips.

HIGHSMITH
He’s back.

Highsmith meets the glare of the barman. Hugo has left him with the bill. He shakes his head and fishes money out of his pocket --

HIGHSMITH (CONT'D)
Definitely back.

EXT. ROAD - DAY

TITLE: **TWO MISSING DAYS**

A gentle rain falls as Kenward’s car drives towards a modest country estate, STYLES. The car horn sends a servant running out to open the gates.

INT. KENWARD’S CAR - DAY

A servant opens Kenward’s car door.

HUGO (O.S.)
Bonjour.

It’s no servant -- Hugo, disheveled but with his mustache somewhat curled, smiles down at Kenward with a bag of biscuits.

KENWARD
(taken aback)
Let me make it clear Detective, that we are not partners, and definitely not friends. I am merely tolerating you at the family’s request. I only ask you not to drink on the job and not to get in the way of my duties. If so, we shall get along smashingly.

Hugo acquiesces with a firm nod.

INT. STYLES - DAY

The BUTLER and the HOUSEKEEPER take Hugo and Kenward's coats. Hugo sees Rosalind standing at the top of the staircase. Meeting his gaze, she turns and disappears down the hallway.

HUGO
She's the spitting image of her mother.

HOUSEKEEPER
(under her breath)
... and just as bold.

BUTLER
Right this way, gentlemen.

THE PARLOUR ROOM

Inside, LOUIS MONTANT MILLER (MONTY, Agatha's younger brother) sits, a ball of nervous energy perusing a newspaper. Beside him, Nan, GEORGE KON (Nan's husband), and MARGARET "MADGE" MILLER (Agatha's older sister), sit around a RADIO.

The scratchy sound of a NEWS REPORT about Agatha's disappearance. News has spread across the country and beyond.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
... sources close to the family suggest Mrs. Christie was in a state of emotional distress since her mother's passing, The Christies refuse to comment.
(beat)
Many are speculating that the mystery of her disappearance bears striking resemblance to her own fiction, leaving readers and officials alike to wonder: is this a grim publicity stunt, or worse, has the Queen of Crime fallen foul of a fate worthy of one of her novels?

NAN
Turn it off, Monty! I can't bear it.

The Butler leads Hugo and Kenward inside.

BUTLER
Constable Kenward and Detective Pieters.

Hugo looks a mess, already sweating. Madge looks him up and down, lights a cigarette.

MADGE
Do come in. I'm Agatha's sister, Madge. This is our brother, Monty. I take it you have some news.

Hugo's gaze stops on Monty who reflexively COVERS HIS FACE WITH THE PAPER.

KENWARD
I'm afraid not, but rest assured, you are all in good hands.

HUGO
(to Monty)
Have we met? You seem familiar. The Stag's Head in Waterloo perhaps?

MONTY
You think *me* familiar? Is that some kind of joke?

MADGE
What are you prattling on about, Monty?

MONTY
Are you all daft? Look at him! The mustache, the cane, and... and... that ridiculous accent!

Hugo raises a brow.

MADGE
Monty.

GEORGE
He does have certain traits I suppose.

NAN
Nonsense. Poirot is short and fat. *

MONTY
And Agatha hated every portrayal of him like that...

MADGE
Enough, all of you. Our sister is in grave danger.

KENWARD
Now, now, let's not jump to conclusions.

NAN
We need to keep our spirits up, Madge.
(to Hugo)
We owe you a debt of gratitude for taking the case, Detective Pieters.

GEORGE
George Kon. Nan is my wife.

MADGE
Nan spoke very highly of you.
Please take a seat.

HUGO
I'd prefer to stretch my legs for a
bit if you don't mind.

Kenward takes a seat along with the rest. Hugo scans the mantlepiece -- old pictures of Agatha and Archie.

NAN
Archie is upstairs with poor
Rosalind. He should be down
shortly.

Hugo moves to the bookcase and picks up THE MYSTERIOUS AFFAIR AT STYLES. He opens the book, the crease cracks --

HUGO
Brand new.

He reads the dust jacket description on the inside fold.

MADGE
She named this home after her first
novel. Morbid, I always thought.

NAN
My suggestion may have had a hand
in that.

MONTY
We've all had a hand in her
success, but not even a mention or
dedication on my part.

MADGE
Not this again.

MONTY
She owes a large debt to those of
us in her life.

HUGO
How so?

MADGE
Agatha collected people. She
invented characters from those she
met, or saw on the street. She
especially enjoyed sprinkling our
personalities into her novels. All
those judgy spinsters? Yours truly.

MONTY
The same ones who turned out to be the jealous killers?

Madge rolls her eyes and then glares at Monty.

GEORGE
I’m still waiting to be immortalized. But I’m hoping for a stuffy aristocratic snob. Better yet, an American!

NAN
Well, that would be exciting. I’m always the trusted friend and confidante. Dull, dull, dull.

GEORGE
In reality, she is far from dull, I assure you.

NAN
Oh, darling...

MONTY
Archie, of course, was always the debonair, worldly gentleman. And me..? Care to take a guess, Detective, what archetype I fulfill?

Monty sits back in a huff. The others laugh, amused.

MONTY (CONT'D)
It’s not funny when bits and pieces of your character emerge wrapped in a vile, nefarious package.

MADGE
Oh, poor Monty. Poor, dear.

Hugo turns the page of the book and finds an inscription -

ARCHIE, ENDINGS ARE OUR BEGINNINGS. FOR ETERNITY, AGATHA.

Hugo zeroes in on one line: FOR ETERNITY

The voices in the room become a dull, indecipherable drone.

KENWARD (O.C.)
Detective Pieters? Are you listening?

Hugo snaps to. Puts the book down. Beads of sweat on his brow.

Kenward meets his gaze, unnerved.

HUGO
May I use the washroom?

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

Hugo heads for the bathroom when he hears VOICES. He presses against the wall, peers into the --

LIBRARY

Hugo sees ARCHIE CHRISTIE, effortlessly dashing, and a reserved young woman, CHARLOTTE FISHER talking in subdued tones. He watches as Archie angrily tears up an ENVELOPE and throws it into the FIREPLACE. They hear MOVEMENT outside. Archie moves towards the doorway and looks down the hall -- EMPTY.

INT. WASHROOM - DAY

Hugo peels off his jacket -- his shirt is drenched in sweat. He gathers himself and splashes water on his face with shaking hands.

He pulls out his prescription bottle. The last two CUBES rattle out. He decides to take them both. He closes his eyes, regains his composure.

CLOSE ON: HUGO’S HAND ON THE SINK. Teressa’s hand slides over his.

INT. LIBRARY - DAY

The room is now empty. At the fireplace, Hugo dreamily uses a poker to fish out an unburned piece of paper, A PHOTO. But only pushes it further. It catches fire.

HUGO
Merde!

He drops the poker, reaches with his hand. A few more inches...

A THROAT CLEARS. Hugo turns.

BUTLER
Sir, may I help you?

HUGO
I was just admiring the mantle.
It’s beautifully crafted.

BUTLER
Quite.

INT. PARLOUR ROOM - DAY

Hugo finds that Archie has joined everyone. His gaze drifts over the room -- dust hangs in the sunlight, a tilted picture frame. He moves with smooth, deliberate ease.

ARCHIE
There you are, Detective. I feared you might have gotten lost.

HUGO
Only metaphorically.

Archie laughs and shakes Hugo's hand vigorously.

ARCHIE
Archibald Christie, Archie. We are grateful to have you here.

HUGO
Hugo Peiters, probably the greatest detective in the world.

Everyone stares at him, taken aback my the boldness. Archie guffaws.

ARCHIE
Well it’s only fitting that Agatha’s detective be as brilliant as she is... Pray, why have you summoned us?

HUGO
To understand your whereabouts at the time of Mrs. Christie's disappearance.

GEORGE
Is this really necessary? The police were here earlier.

KENWARD
This was not my idea, sir. I'm simply here to indulge *your* detective.

Hugo turns to the family, relaxed, hands loose at his sides.

MONTY
Madge and I arrived yesterday morning. How can we possibly be of any help to you?

MADGE
I was with friends in Cheshire.

GEORGE
We were at home. I fell asleep early. Right, darling?

NAN
Yes, and I did a bit of reading before joining you.

Everyone turns to Monty.

Hugo notices that Charlotte and the servants are gathered outside, eavesdropping.

MONTY
You can't possibly...

HUGO
There is no cause for alarm.

MONTY
But you're insinuating...

ARCHIE
Monty, collect yourself. He's simply doing his job.

HUGO
We can revisit your whereabouts when your mind is less cloudy, Mr. Miller.

MONTY
When *my* mind is less cloudy!?

Monty contains his anger.

ARCHIE
(to Hugo)
I am an open book, detective.
(MORE)

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
But I've been inside for so long, and since the rain has stopped, I could use a bit of fresh air and some exercise.

HUGO
I'll join you.

EXT. STYLES - WOODS - DAY

Located in the back of the estate, Hugo watches the fog swirling on the ground as he follows Archie through a footpath. Archie wears a hunting jacket and boots. He carries a rifle.

ARCHIE
Come on, detective, let's not dally.

HUGO
When you said a bit of fresh air --

ARCHIE
I usually would go to the club to play golf, but the course is waterlogged today.

They step over a low stone wall into deeper brush.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
This was her favorite walk, you know. Said the silence helped her plot.

HUGO
You don't strike me as a man who enjoys silence.

ARCHIE
Silence isn't the problem. It's what comes after.

Hugo struggles to keep pace with Archie, out of shape and out of breath. Archie allows Hugo to catch up.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
Agatha was planning a writing retreat to Beverley, her assistant Charlotte was organising it - when Agatha's bitten by her muse, it's best to stay out of her way. Her moods are... unpredictable.

Hugo scrutinizes Archie as he scans the woods for game.

HUGO
Has your wife always been so--?

ARCHIE
Determined? Yes, Agatha was never one to suffer fools gladly.

Archie moves forward, slow and sure, hunting.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
It’s what attracted me to her in the first place.

He freezes. Raises his hand to stop Hugo.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
There.

Hugo follows his gaze as the fog thickens around them. Hugo walks through the fog until it lightens to mist.

The faint sound of men's laughter --

EXT. COUNTRY HALL LAWN (EXETER) - MEMORY - DAY

Hugo walks out from the summer haze to find a MILITARY PICNIC SOCIAL. Tables dressed in linen topped by glass vessels with lemonade.

Officers in uniform socialize among young women in modest pastel dresses as a military band plays a bouyant tune.

Hugo joins Archie who's surrounded by other young offices who stare at someone in the distance. Hugo from the back, stands on his tiptoes and leans to try and getter a better look until his gaze lands on --

AGATHA sits slightly apart at a long trestle table, hat pinned neatly, writing in a notebook.

The most recently rejected SOLDIER/FRIEND returns to the group, greeted by laughter.

FRIEND
She’s impossible, just scribbles in that notebook. Anyway, she’s quite plain up close.

ARCHIE
I’m always up for a challenge.

FRIEND
You love the hunt -- but rarely the catch.

Laughter from his friends. Archie smiles mischievously.

ARCHIE
What is she writing?

FRIEND
That information will cost you.

ARCHIE
Will an introduction to my fair cousin suffice?

His friend's interest is piqued. *

LATER *

Hugo watches as Archie gracefully crosses towards Agatha, stands there, and clears his throat.

AGATHA
(without looking)
I'm sorry, I'm just not feeling well enough to dance.

ARCHIE
May I sit?

He takes a seat without waiting for an answer. Agatha glances up and his handsome features catch her eye. She returns to her notebook.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
What are you writing? Wait, let me guess...

AGATHA
If you say romance, I will absolutely scream.

Archie scrutinizes her for a moment, staring into her eyes until she looks away.

ARCHIE
Certainly not - you seem far too * serious for anything so * sentimental. *

Agatha cocks her head.

AGATHA
Do you find a lot of time to read between all that military training?

ARCHIE
Not so much...

Archie surveys the room, making a point not to look at her.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
But I do love reading *mysteries.* Have you ever heard of Dorothy Sayers? I adore her stories.

She looks to Archie, who keeps his attention on the dancing couples. Agatha puts her pen and notebook down.

Archie smiles. Hugo is suddenly at his shoulder --

HUGO
You lied to gain her favor?

EXT. STYLES - WOODS - DAY (PRESENT)

Archie keeps his eyes trained on the sights of his gun for a moment before --

ARCHIE
It’s called flirting, Pieters.

HUGO
Did you struggle to find work after the war, Mr. Christie?

ARCHIE
Didn’t everyone?

HUGO
You were never bitter about Agatha’s career? It’s hard to be the husband of such a successful woman, I imagine.

ARCHIE
I’m a modern man. If it weren’t for Agatha’s writing, I doubt I would even be alive.

HUGO
How so?

ARCHIE
During the war. She wrote to me. Stories. Every week, sometimes two. But never the endings. I had to return home to her to find out the endings.

HUGO
I too was on the frontline, and I understand what those communiques from home meant.

BOOM! Archie fires. Hugo flinches, the gunshot rattling him.

Archie strides past Hugo towards a fallen deer.

DEEPER IN THE WOODS

Archie stands over the deer, which struggles to breathe, inspecting it. Hugo walks over to him. *

ARCHIE
Did you kill anyone during the war?

Hugo remains silent.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
Self-preservation is a powerful motivation, don’t you think?

Archie FIRES again, ending the dear's life in a sadistic fashion.

INT. STYLES - KITCHEN - DAY

A piece of butchered venison sizzles in a pan. It is plated and brought to Hugo at a servants' table.

He stares at it queasily as the Housekeeper pours a glass of wine, takes a gulp to settle his stomach.

Charlotte Fisher, Agatha's personal assistant, sits across the table, straight-backed, ladylike, and takes a sip of tea.

HUGO
Go on, please...

Charlotte sets down her teacup -- lipstick print left behind. A distinct shade of coral.

CHARLOTTE
Well, I thought perhaps I might learn something. She said I had talent. That I could be... something.

Hugo motions for a refill of wine.

CHARLOTTE (CONT'D)
She worked too hard; that was the truth of it. That’s what writing is, isn’t it? A kind of polite madness.

INT. AGATHA’S OFFICE - NIGHT (MEMORY)

She approaches Agatha’s desk. It's littered with photographs of potential characters with notes about them. There are also elements from her vanity for quick touch-ups.

CHARLOTTE (V.O.)
I suppose I envied that.

She picks up a tube of lipstick and applies a cupid’s bow to her lips. She admires the coral color in the mirror.

She moves on to an elegant Parisian purse with a zipper. Then something catches her eye -- A FUR COAT.

Charlotte lifts it, hesitates, then presses it to her face. She wraps herself in it. Spins once in front of the mirror.

FROM THE MIRROR, Hugo watches her.

CHARLOTTE (V.O.)
We had a deal, she and I.
I would handle the world -- the appointments, the letters, the reviews -- and she would teach me how to shape a story.

HUGO (V.O.)
Did she keep her promise?

INT. STYLES - KITCHEN - DAY (PRESENT)

Charlotte breaks his gaze. Sips her tea.

CHARLOTTE
She kept more secrets than promises.

INT. AGATHA'S OFFICE - NIGHT (MEMORY)

Charlotte opens a drawer. Inside a manuscript box wrapped in twine. She unties it, flips a few pages --

A SOUND downstairs. Agatha's voice, approaching.

Charlotte hurriedly tucks the manuscript back in the drawer, moves to the door but footsteps approach.

INT. AGATHA'S OFFICE / WARDROBE - CONTINUOUS

Charlotte slips inside. Closes the door. Hugo is already in here -- impossibly. Sharing the small space with her.

CHARLOTTE
I shouldn't have opened it. She told me never to touch the drafts.

Through the cracks Hugo watches --

INT. AGATHA'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Agatha, disheveled, bursts in with her notebooks and paces before her Dictaphone. Turns on the recorder.

AGATHA
Testing...
(beat)
My dear detective...

In the closet --

CHARLOTTE
(quietly)
She uses that thing to talk to Poirot when she gets an idea.

Hugo leans for a better view.

AGATHA
Hastings thinks you've gone mad. Senile. He doesn't understand you. But I do. I believe you could solve anything.

Agatha looks up -- directly into the mirror. For a moment her eyes appear to meet Hugo's through the crack in the wardrobe door.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
The world doesn’t know what to do with people like us.
(beat)
We’re inconvenient.

INT. STYLES - KITCHEN - DAY (PRESENT)

HUGO
And that’s when you last saw her?

CHARLOTTE
Later that night, I returned from Farnham. There was a literary society thing. Dreadful food, worse readings.

INT. STYLES - FOYER - NIGHT (MEMORY)

Charlotte closes the door behind her. She hangs her coat and is immediately greeted by Peter, tail wagging.

CHARLOTTE
Hello Peter. Did you miss me, boy?

Charlotte looks up and sees the servants at the stairs nervously waiting for her.

CHARLOTTE (CONT'D)
What is it?

The Housekeeper motions to the note on the console table. Charlotte opens the heavy-grade, quality paper and reads --

FLASH TO:

Agatha, looking at us.

AGATHA
Carlotta, I've been deceived. My head is bursting. I cannot stay in this house any longer. Cancel my reservations at Beverley.

INT. STYLES KITCHEN - DAY (PRESENT)

Charlotte hands Hugo the pencil-written note. He holds it to the light. The paper is embossed with a swan emblem, and further down he sees two words have been erased --"I'm scared..."

HUGO
She was afraid to be in her own home?

CHARLOTTE
I couldn't say.

HUGO
You don't have to. It's right here.
(beat)
Did Agatha leave nothing for Archie? No letter, no envelope?

CHARLOTTE
Not that I know of.

Hugo lets the silence stretch. Charlotte meets his gaze. Her expression, unreadable.

HUGO
Thank you.

INT. STYLES HALLWAY - DAY

Hugo waits near the door discreetly looking down at the CHARRED PHOTO from the fire place -

Pictured are two couples. The first is unrecognizable. The second is Archie standing next to a WOMAN - burn marks obscuring her face.

Hugo tucks the photo back into his coat pocket as Nan appears with an envelope of cash which she hands to Hugo.

NAN
Consider this a down payment.

Hugo hesitates, but takes it.

HUGO
She has a concerned family, but it is you who sought me out.

NAN
Agatha and I grew up together. We volunteered together... Were you in the war, Mr. Pieters? *

Hugo looks down.

FLASH TO: IN A TRENCH HIS LEG IS TORN APART WITH SHRAPNEL

BACK TO:

Hugo looks back at Nan.

HUGO
I was.

NAN
Agatha did her bit (for the war effort), too. She could never sit still. *

WOMAN'S VOICE (O.S.)
D'accord! Calmez-vous!

A RUCKUS draws Hugo's attention he looks off, and walks into--

INT. MAKE-SHIFT HOSPITAL WARD - DAY (MEMORY)

In an old town hall a hoard of FRENCH and ENGLISH SOLDIERS with horrendous war injuries convalesce around a YOUNGER AGATHA CHRISTIE. She hands out pages from her notebook. Eager hands grab and read them.

AGATHA
D’accord! Don’t worry, I promised everyone a turn.

The Soldiers jeer.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
Don't be crude!

Soldier #1 reads his letter.

SOLDIER #1
I was wounded, but only after saving a platoon of men?!

SOLDIER #2
(laughing)
He tripped over his untied shoelaces and shot his own foot.

The other soldiers laugh. Hugo joins the group, watching.

AGATHA
(to Soldier #2)
I don't know why you're laughing; you’re a secret agent who will help win the war for the Allies.

The soldiers sing her praises. Agatha bathes in the adoration and moves on, handing out more letters.

Hugo watches her go, amused. He follows her into--

INT. CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Nan, carrying linen, almost runs into Agatha.

NAN
Agatha, for heaven’s sake. Where have you been?

Agatha raises her finger to her lips to shush Nan and slips into a room. Nan rolls her eyes, then she sees Hugo behind.

NAN (CONT'D)
You’re not supposed to be here.

HUGO
No. I’m just watching.

She considers him sternly then lets it go, they peer into--

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Agatha can be seen sitting by a patient's bedside - a woman * obscured behind a sheer curtain reads a letter. Nan doesn't * enter, something about this feels intimate and private.

AGATHA
Is it too much? C’est bien?

PATIENT
C’est bien.

The patient hands the letter back to Agatha before being beset by a coughing fit.

INT. CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

Agatha rises, moves past Nan.

AGATHA
She needs her rest.

Nan follows Agatha into--

INT. PRESS ROOM - DAY (A LATER MEMORY)

A press conference. Journalists crowd a low stage.

Agatha pulls Nan through the crowded space to find a seat in the back. She pulls out a notepad.

NAN (V.O.)
After the war, we'd sneak into press briefings. Morgues. Court trials.

Agatha furiously scribbles. Unblinking. Absorbing.

The man speaking at the podium is out of focus – we never quite see him clearly.

NAN
(hushed)
Honestly, it's one thing to write correspondence to soldiers' girlfriends...

AGATHA
You don't think I'm capable of writing a mystery?

Agatha takes a photo of the podium with her pocket camera.

NAN
Maybe men are better suited for such things. It's in their nature.

AGATHA
What will you have me write, romances?

NAN
Nothing wrong with a good romance...

AGATHA
Romance is merely the triumph of imagination over intelligence.

NAN
Very well, if you write a mystery and I can't figure out the culprit, then I will grovel at your feet and beg forgiveness.

AGATHA
Deal.

INT. STYLES HALLWAY - DAY (PRESENT)

NAN
You can surmise who won that bet.

Hugo smiles.

NAN (CONT'D)
When someone’s been in your life so long, you forget where they end and you begin... and when they’re gone, you’re not sure what’s left of you.

Hugo instinctively touches his pocket watch.

HUGO
I understand.

EXT. STYLES - CONTINUOUS

Before climbing into the car, Hugo stops in front of Archie’s car and checks the headlight: INTACT.

Hugo sees Monty gazing down at him from a second-story window. Hugo nods. Monty withdraws inside.

Hugo climbs into Kenward’s car.

INT. CAR - CONTINUOUS

KENWARD
Well, that was a waste of time.

HUGO
Thank you for seeing me this far. I should just make it. * *

As Hugo reaches into his pocket to check the time his prescription bottle falls out onto the car floor. Kenward picks it up and inspects it. It's empty.

HUGO (CONT'D)
(embarrassed)
A war injury. The minute I met Monty, I knew we shared the same affliction. He seems beholden to something stronger.

KENWARD
I won’t tolerate any sort of impropriety...

HUGO
I can assure you, it’s simply to manage the pain.

Kenward hands the pill bottle to Hugo, suspicious.

KENWARD
Is Inspector Highsmith aware of this prescription?

HUGO
Of course.

Kenward drives them away.

INT. CHEMIST’S - EVENING

Hugo crosses a dark street and enters the Chemist’s.

KENWARD (V.O.)
Get some rest. Tomorrow we search the ponds.

Hugo takes out the envelope of cash and pays the pharmacist for a bottle of pills. He pops one as he leaves the shop.

INT. HUGO'S OFFICE - NIGHT

By lamplight, Hugo reads "MYSTERIOUS AFFAIR AT STYLES" jotting things down in his notebook. Then reads on the page --

"Poirot stroked his own magnificent mustache tenderly..."

Hugo is stroking his own mustache. He stops instantly, turns to the back of the book to find--

A PHOTO OF THE AUTHOR. Agatha wears a man’s hat and tie, and she stares back at him wistfully. He ponders her.

EXT. NEWLANDS CORNER VALLEY - MORNING

SUPER: **THREE MISSING DAYS**

A NEWSPAPER BOY hawks newspapers through the GROWING CROWD --

NEWSPAPER BOY
Mystery Novelist Vanishes! Police Search In Vain!

REPORTERS and ONLOOKERS have DOUBLED. Police use sticks to poke through overgrown shrubs and nearby pools and ponds. Search dogs howl, excited.

Kenward and Hugo walk together. Kenward is exasperated. He is offered a paper by the newspaper boy.

KENWARD
Get out of here!

A shouting match draws both their attention, and they walk towards a nearby --

EXT. NEWLANDS CORNER - POOL - MORNING

Where police duo, ALTON DAVIES and BLAKE WILLIAMS, square off with fellow officers, EVANS and TAYLOR.

KENWARD
What on earth is going on here?

ALTON
These two wankers are muscling in on our investigation... and our reward.

BLAKE
We were here first --

EVANS
You don’t own it. We have every right to be here.

ALTON
Oh, is that right?

Alton starts to disrobe to his undergarments.

ALTON (CONT'D)
This area is ours! Search elsewhere.

Alton dives in, searching through the cold, muddy waters. The others follow suit in a frenzy. Kenward throws his hands up in disbelief. Hugo is enjoying the show.

KENWARD
This is ridiculous.

HUGO
Superbe. Shall I tell them Mrs. Christie is not down there?

KENWARD
What makes you so sure?

HUGO
Because, mon ami --

An officer interrupts, approaching through the scrum of reporters toward Hugo and Kenward.

OFFICER
Constable Kenward! You have an urgent message.

Hugo and Kenward share a look.

INT. DOYLE RESIDENCE - PARLOUR ROOM - DAY *

Hugo and Kenward sit at a round table in the dark room, lit by candlelight. Hugo reaches for his hand, Kenward slaps his away. * * *

KENWARD *
This was the emergency? *

Hugo looks on amused. Next to them, clasping hands are Madge and Archie, who looks embarrassed. * *

MADGE
I'm glad you're both here.

ARCHIE
Madge was...persuasive. *

KENWARD
We were informed there was a development. * *

DOYLE (OS)
Indeed there is! *

Two figures emerge -- a stately man with a large mustache, SIR ARTHUR CONAN DOYLE, and a matronly woman, DOROTHY L. SAYERS - yes, the famed authors, stand to greet them.

DOYLE (CONT'D)
Welcome.

MADGE
Mr. Doyle...

DOYLE
Arthur, please. Come forward, everyone, please.
(MORE)

DOYLE (CONT'D)
This is Mrs. Dorothy Sayers. We were... ARE both dear friends of Agatha's.

ARCHIE
(quiet, to Hugo)
Dear friends, until her book sales exceeded theirs.

SAYERS
Poor, dear Agatha. We felt it our duty to help however we could.

KENWARD
I'm confused. Why exactly are we here?

DOYLE
To find her, of course. We are very lucky that the Amazing Abramovic has agreed to help us.

HUGO
The amazing who..?

SAYERS
The Amazing Abramovic has helped the police solve many cases around the world. We are very lucky to have him here.

DOYLE
When we heard about Agatha's disappearance, we vowed to use our combined investigative talents to find her.

Hugo and Kenward share glances - did he say "investigative talents?"

DOYLE (CONT'D)
With the kind aid of the Amazing Abramovic --

HUGO
And how would he help us, exactly?

DOYLE
Through a seance.

KENWARD
Oh, of course...

SAYERS
Quickly now, everyone, take your seats.

Madge leans over to Kenward and Hugo.

MADGE
Please, we can't leave any stone unturned. Humor me if you must.

Hugo heads for his seat. Kenward begrudgingly follows.

The parlour room door opens, and a slender, sharp-featured man, pale, gaunt with a pencil mustache, steps into the light and unceremoniously yawns.

KENWARD
The Amazing Abramovic, I presume.

ABRAMOVIC
I apologize, I'm quite tired from my travels. Before we begin, shall we attend to the formalities?

DOYLE
But of course, forgive me.

Doyle hands Abramovic an envelope, which he tucks inside his coat. Kenward rolls his eyes.

HUGO
That accent, I cannot place it. Where in Russia are you from? I'm usually good with accents.

ABRAMOVIC
From many places. My family moved a lot. Shall we begin?

Everyone around the table nods.

ABRAMOVIC (CONT'D)
I need something that belongs to Mrs. Christie.

Doyle pulls out a single glove.

DOYLE
She left this at one of my parties.

ABRAMOVIC
Everyone join hands. Close your eyes.
(everyone does)
(MORE)

ABRAMOVIC (CONT'D)
Think about your missing loved one. Focus all your energy and manifest her in your mind's eye.

Hugo opens one of his eyes. Abramovic stares at him.

ABRAMOVIC (CONT'D)
There are disbelievers here. This will not work unless you clear your mind of doubt and focus on Mrs. Christie. Focus on what she means to you. And whatever happens you must not break the circle.

Hugo closes his eyes. Kenward does the same.

Abramovic closes his eyes, and his calm face slowly darkens. His head jerks backwards, he shakes violently and then goes still. He opens glazed eyes

ABRAMOVIC (CONT'D)
I see her. She is lost. Alone. In a very dark place. A place she can't free herself from. Very dark.

MADGE
Oh, goodness.

ARCHIE
Is she... all right? Where is she?

ABRAMOVIC
She's in pain. Tremendous pain. Alone. In darkness. Betrayed by someone she deeply cared for.

ARCHIE
Tell us where she is!

The candles all blow out at once - a collective gasp. Abramovic holds his head in his hands.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
I demand you tell us where my wife is! You said she's in pain. Is she hurt? Is she alive?

ABRAMOVIC
So much worry and concern. Had she known earlier, events may have unfolded differently.

ARCHIE
(standing, furious)
What are you implying? This is ridiculous!

Archie storms out. Hugo watches him. Doyle and Sayers profusely apologize to Abramovic.

KENWARD
Thank you for all this. Very, very enlightening.

Kenward rises and leaves. Hugo is about to follow --

ABRAMOVIC
I was born in Moscow but raised in Prague. That may account for my strange accent. Much like you... you left Belgium after the war, yes? After your wife...?

Hugo stares at him, taken aback.

ABRAMOVIC (CONT'D)
She had a Swedish mother, did she not? No one could place her accent either. It was the first question you asked her when you met.
(off Hugo's astonishment)
She has only a matter of days. And it seems that you are the only one who can find her.

With that, Abramovic exits the room, leaving a stunned Hugo.

EXT. DOYLE RESIDENCE - MOMENTS LATER

Hugo heads toward Kenward's car, deep in thought.

MADGE (O.S.)
They argued.

Madge leans in the archway, cigarette between her fingers.

MADGE (CONT'D)
My sister is not a conventional woman, as you know. It's caused upset over the years.

HUGO
What sort of upset?

MADGE
When Agatha was starting out, I was often asked to help with Rosalind - someone had to.

The camera pans off Hugo into--

INT. LONDON FLAT - DAY (MEMORY)

Agatha enters and passes the kitchen where Madge is cooking. Hugo stands near by.

AGATHA
I got it, Madge. Archie, Mr. Lane says he'll publish!

MADGE
That's nice, dear.

ARCHIE (O.C.)
Be right over.

AGATHA
I have to finish the pages.

INT. LONDON FLAT, OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Agatha breezes into her small office to find photos and pages of notes have been ripped off the walls.

A younger Rosalind, hands covered in ink, smears handprints all over them on the floor.

AGATHA
Rosalind!

Agatha furiously grabs Rosalind's wrist, squeezing it.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
My pages. What have you done!?

Rosalind squeals in pain. Archie bursts in. Madge is already in the doorway. Hugo behind.

ARCHIE
Agatha! In heavens name!

MADGE
Aggie, she's just a child!

Agatha realizes what she's doing and lets Rosalind's hand go. She hugs the girl tight.

AGATHA
I'm so sorry, darling. I don't know what came over me. Your mother's under a lot of pressure...

Rosalind struggles free from Agatha's arms and runs to Madge. Agatha and Madge's eyes meet - an unspoken tension between them.

Archie closes the study doors and they can be heard arguing.

AGATHA (O.S.) (CONT'D)
I'm working for us! A new home, that car you've had your eye on, your very own membership at the golf club!

ARCHIE (O.S.)
I told you I'm meeting meeting Mr. Harcourt about a job next week --

Madge looks toward the closed doors not with hatred, but something colder. As she holds onto Rosalind, Hugo watches.

EXT. DOYLE RESIDENCE - PRESENT

Madge crushes the cigarette under her heel.

MADGE
Brilliance doesn't excuse cruelty. Especially not with a little girl caught in the middle.

HUGO
Do you know of a couple who doesn't argue?

MADGE
I don't. But not every woman's marriage requires a supporting cast.

Hugo studies her as she walks away -- just enough resentment to make him wonder.

KENWARD (O.C.)
Pieters! Chop, chop!

Hugo snaps to and makes his way towards waiting Kenward.

INT. SURREY POLICE STATION - EVENING

Kenward leads Hugo down a narrow corridor.

KENWARD
Monty hasn’t set foot back in Styles since our last visit. We can’t find him anywhere.

HUGO
From his present condition, he won’t get very far.

KENWARD
Like you on this case?

Hugo looks at Kenward, a slight smile on his lips as he leads Hugo into a small, cluttered office.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
Will this space suffice?

Hugo leans into the dark office, inspecting the haphazard piles of files and paperwork.

HUGO
It’s perfect.

LATER

Hugo bites off HALF A CUBE and turns on a record player. Classical music fills the room. It energizes Hugo, who closes his eyes and sways slightly to the music.

INT. AGATHA’S OFFICE - NIGHT (MEMORY)

Agatha paces, looking at the blank page in the typewriter.

BACK TO:

HUGO SWAYING. HIS EYES OPEN

A FLASH OF CHARLOTTE sipping tea - a brief flash of fear in her eyes.

Hugo takes Charlotte’s picture and pins it to the wall of suspects.

ARCHIE shoots the gasping deer in cold blood.

CLOSE on the envelope being tossed in the fireplace.

Archie’s picture is pinned.

ROSALIND’S sullen eyes stare at him from the top of the staircase.

MADGE blows smoke into a curl.

Hugo pins Madge’s picture on the wall.

MONTY looks down from a second-floor window, then steps back out of view.

Hugo regards Monty’s picture for a few moments... then places on the wall

Hugo looks at the ever-growing case wall. His eyes gleam. He adds more notes and pictures, and it’s starting to resemble --

INT. AGATHA’S OFFICE - NIGHT (MEMORY)

A MOSAIC PUZZLE of notes. Agatha re-arranges her notes and photographs of characters, and once again, inspiration hits her. She begins to write.

INT. SURREY POLICE - NIGHT

Hugo steps back. The tapestry of the suspects' pictures stretches before him. Scattered among them are pages of Agatha's novels with notes and underlined sentences -- order and chaos in equal measure. And at the center of it all--

A PHOTOGRAPH OF AGATHA - still and unreadable.

Teressa rests her chin on Hugo's shoulder, both of them analyzing the enigmatic femme fatale.

POLICE STATION - HALLS

Kenward looks at his watch as he hears the last of the officers leaving for the night, they pass Hugo's office.

ALTON
This is the expert the family brought in?

BLAKE
All he’s managed to find is the off-license on the corner.

They laugh as they leave.

INT. OFFICE - MOMENTS LATER

Kenward knocks and peers into the room, impressed by the schematic Hugo created on the wall.

KENWARD
It’s time to head home, Pieters. We’ll continue first thing in the morning.

Hugo remains focused on the wall.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
Pieters?

Hugo is lost in thought, staring at his mind map. Kenward can’t help but admire this side of Hugo.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
Good night.

Kenward slips out, and when the door closes, Hugo snaps out of his reverie and realizes he’s alone.

Hugo steps up to the wall where the TITLE PAGE of one of Agatha’s novels is pinned. In large print it says THE BODLEY HEAD PUBLISHING COMPANY.

EXT. LONDON STREETS - DAY

A large sign: THE BODLEY HEAD PUBLISHING COMPANY.

Hugo heads up the steps of a smart town house.

SUPER: **FOUR MISSING DAYS**

INT. ELEVATOR - DAY

As Hugo's rises in a caged elevator he glimpses a woman, her face obscured, slipping down the staircase.

INT. BODLEY HEAD - MR. LANE'S OFFICE - DAY

ALLEN LANE, brash, is on the telephone. A RECEPTIONIST shows Hugo to the door. Lane waves him --

LANE
(on the call)
Yes, I'm aware the papers are circling, that's what papers do... *
(smiling thinly) *
(MORE)

LANE (CONT'D)
Of course it helps sales. She *
didn’t earn the title Mistress of *
Suspense by being dull. *

Hugo is confronted with an easel of a mock-up for the next Christie release: "THE QUEEN CRIME’S FINAL TALE. A Masterpiece From Beyond the Grave."

Beneath it is portrait of HERCULE POIROT leaning on a cane and twisting the tips of his mustache. Hugo realizes that he, too, is leaning on his cane twisting his mustache. He drops his hand and sits.

LANE (CONT'D)
(on call)
No, I'm not at liberty to say...
All in good time...Yes. You’ll have *
the first excerpt. Provided you *
behave. *

He hangs up brusquely. *

Hugo preternaturally scans the desk -- A TEACUP WITH A FAINT LIPSTICK MARK ON THE RIM, and a MANUSCRIPT BOX TIED WITH TWINE. Lane follows his gaze and casually covers the box with his newspaper.

LANE (CONT'D) *
Detective. I trust this isn't a *
social call? *

HUGO
Just a few questions. I'll be
brief, I see how busy you are.

LANE
If you return my best-selling *
author to me, you may detain me as *
long as you like. *

HUGO
Would you be so kind as to describe
Mrs. Christie's state during your
last few meetings?

LANE
I'm a blunt man so I'll be blunt.
Agatha had become...taxing. Grief *
is inconvenient for everyone. *
Deadlines don't move because a *
mother dies. *

This lands harder than intended. *

LANE (CONT'D) *
(slightly softening) *
But she wrote, she always wrote. *
That was never the difficulty. *

HUGO *
Then what was? *

LANE *
She'd begin to believe that rules *
no longer applied to her. *
Appointments optional contracts *
flexible. Editors decorative. *

Lane composes his growing irritation. *

LANE (CONT'D)
My father discovered her, you know.
Nurtured her career. Took risks on
a female mystery writer when no one
else would. *

HUGO
Her calendar noted an appointment a
few days ago. Did she come?

LANE
I saw her. Briefly. *

Hugo feels a drop of water on his face. Wipes it away.
Another drop falls.

LANE (CONT'D)
It was raining that day --

Hugo looks up.

POV -- the rain falls from the clouds.

EXT. LONDON STREET - DAY (MEMORY)

Rain falls steadily on a shop-filled street. Lane opens his
umbrella. Hugo follows alongside, trying to keep dry as well.

LANE (V.O.)
But I'd decided to get a head start
on my Christmas shopping.

CAROL SINGERS sing 'O Come All Ye Faithful' to shoppers as
they pass.

Lane sees Agatha exit a JEWELRY SHOP across the road -- she
is bedraggled and wet from the rain.

LANE
Agatha?!

Lane crosses the street after her, Hugo at his heels. Agatha sees him but keeps walking, with no regard for how wet she's getting.

AGATHA
Mr. Lane? What are you doing here?

LANE
Come under my umbrella, you'll catch your death.

AGATHA
I'm perfectly fine thank you.

LANE
Did you forget about our appointment?

AGATHA
Something came up. I apologize.

LANE
Perhaps it’s time you started thinking about others for a change.

This gets Agatha’s attention.

AGATHA
I’ve done everything you’ve ever asked. I’ve met every impossible deadline. My writing has taken all the time I should be devoting to my husband and daughter.

LANE
That's your choice, not mine.

AGATHA
In return I’ve only asked for my fair share of the profits - a privilege granted to our friend Mr. Conan Doyle - yet you laughed in my face. I have a family to support.

LANE
And Mr. Doyle has two.

AGATHA
That's his choice, not mine.

LANE
This is business, Agatha.

Agatha regains her composure.

AGATHA
Very well, I'll have another Superintendent Battle novel finished for you in a few months, and that will fulfill all my contractual obligations.

LANE
Battle? No, I want your latest Poirot.

Agatha looks at him, taken aback.

LANE (CONT'D)
I know it's almost finished, and from the look of its toll on you, it must be spectacular. I expect that on my desk next week, if you please.

AGATHA
I would rather die than let you get your grubby hands on that manuscript.

Agatha walks away getting wet, leaving Lane with Hugo.

HUGO
Interesting choice of words.

INT. PUBLISHER'S OFFICE - DAY (PRESENT)

LANE
She wasn't talking sense. She owed me that novel and she knew it.

Hugo glances at the poster on the easel.

HUGO
I'm curious. Do posthumous novels sell better than those with living authors?

LANE
In publishing one must prepare for all eventualities.
(MORE)

LANE (CONT'D)
I've a 'Return of The Mystery Queen' one somewhere out there. Though I like the artwork on this one better.

HUGO
Where were you on Friday night?

LANE
The days blend together. Most likely I was at the Gargoyle.

HUGO
No doubt with friends who can attest to that?

LANE
No doubt.

HUGO
Thank you, Mr. Lane. You've been most helpful.

Hugo casually reaches to shake Lane's hand and accidentally knocks his teacup over. Mr. Lane quickly jumps up to keep the tea from spilling on his suit.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Oh dear. How clumsy of me.

Lane leaps up with a handkerchief.

LANE
Good grief, man! Mary, Mary!

His receptionist rushes in with napkins and fusses over him.

HUGO
I'm terribly sorry.

LANE
It's fine. Just go.

INT. HUGO'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Hugo places the MANUSCRIPT on his desk and stares at it. It feels like a violation - but after a few moments, he unties the twine and opens it.

CLOSE ON THE TITLE PAGE: **CURTAIN by AGATHA CHRISTIE**

HUGO
It seems you could not trust anyone.

In the mirror behind him, we see AGATHA reflected. It seems that she too is starting to encroach on Hugo’s space.

INT. HUGO'S OFFICE - NIGHT (PRESENT)

Hours later, Hugo pores over CURTAIN. Agatha is there again, now reading over his shoulder.

AGATHA
(reading)
I went into Poirot before going down to breakfast. He was in bed, and I was struck again by how ill he looked. Deep lines of weariness and fatigue were on his face. “How are you, old boy?” He smiled impatiently at me.

HUGO
(reading)
"I exist, my friend. I still exist."

He turns the page; that’s all there is. Hugo’s face twists in consternation -- the manuscript’s not finished. He stands, almost angry. Hugo instinctually takes out his bottle of pills, but resists taking one. He paces.

EXT. NEWLANDS CORNER - MORNING

SUPER: **FIVE MISSING DAYS**

Hugo’s prediction has been realized - it’s now a CIRCUS.

REPORTERS from all over the world set up camp. POLICE OFFICERS wrangle the search dogs while ONLOOKERS watch from picnic blankets, like a spectator sport.

Hugo passes a COLLECTION OF DREDGED UP ITEMS laid out on a tarpaulin. Everything from old Wellington boots to a sink.

Kenward stands at the edge of a LAKE as divers submerge themselves, his countenance a nervous wreck. Hugo approaches.

HUGO
They even have a kitchen sink.

KENWARD
It’s not funny.

A search plane buzzes overhead.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
You told me she would not be found at the bottom of a pond. Why not?

HUGO
Because, mon brave, that was the third day. And in these conditions a body pops up, POUF, after two.

KENWARD
Why didn’t you tell me that before!?

HUGO
I did try.

A diver BURSTS OUT OF THE POOL, FLAILING and YELLING at the top of his lungs. Kenward smiles, smug.

KENWARD
Maybe Hugo Pieters is wrong.

They rush towards the pool. A STIFF CORPSE is dragged out. Onlookers and reporters clamor to get closer.

REPORTER #1
Is that her?!!

HUGO
I suppose, if she had recently graced the windows of Selfridges.

After taking a closer look, Kenward’s face falls. The corpse is in fact a discarded MANNEQUIN.

EXT. ROAD - DAY

Kenward storms toward his car. Hugo follows after him.

KENWARD
This is the costliest search ever mounted, and there’s not a single trace. It’s as if she’s disappeared off the face of the earth. We’re becoming an embarrassment.

HUGO
We? Non. This was your search.

Kenward explodes.

KENWARD
Oh, so now you don't want to be partners. Now you're not my 'ami' or 'mon brave'! I see. I see. Well, you know what? I've spent the last five days with you following me around smelling like the bad end of a wine bottle, sweating and staggering and drifting off to God knows where. Out of the two of us, guess who's the embarrassment? It's you, Pieters! YOU! Are you going to be the one to tell Highsmith about your pill popping, or am I?!

Silence. Hugo looks at him --

Then he hands Kenward his bottle of pills, and leaves.

EXT. NEWLANDS CORNER, BUS STOP - MOMENTS LATER

Hugo at a bus stop. A bus pulls up. He starts to board--

KENWARD (O.C.)
Oi!

Hugo turns. Kenward has chased after him.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
What would you have me do?!

A moment.

HUGO
Forget the body. Analyze the suspects. Each suspect holds a thousand little details, without knowing they are doing so. Examine the details and it will lead you to the truth!

Kenward slumps and relents.

KENWARD
D'accord.

HUGO
D'accord?

Kenward nods. Hugo smiles. *

An OLD LADY behind him, stout, formidable, clutching parcels. *

OLD LADY *
Well either board it or marry it, *
dear. *

Hugo dismounts as the Old Lady elbows past him *

HUGO
It may require some breaking of
some rules.

KENWARD
Why am I not surprised? *

INT. LONDON PUB - NIGHT

A forgotten corner of London. Cigarette smoke clings to the air. Hugo and Kenward sit in the back. They watch a WELL-GROOMED MAN who sits in a dark corner by a window.

HUGO
The local pharmacist. He’s been
charged with distributing cocaine
without a proper prescription
prior. He’ll help in exchange for
leniency on past charges. I
promised we would do our best.

KENWARD
Not quite the most forthright plan,
but I like the ingenuity.

HUGO
It’s time to lure the mouse out of
hiding.

The PHARMACIST shifts nervously, looking over at them.

HUGO (CONT'D)
His collywobbles will give away our
gambit.
(beat)
I’m going to buy some tobacco.

KENWARD
Now?

HUGO
Eases the nerves.

Hugo heads for the back. Kenward keeps watch over the nervous Pharmacist.

Kenward's gaze shifts to the window. He sees Monty peering. Kenward looks for Hugo but can't find him.

Monty enters and takes a seat next to the Pharmacist, who pulls out a small vial. Monty takes it and slides an envelope towards him in return. The Pharmacist grows nervous and, despite his best efforts, glances over to Kenward. Monty follows his gaze and sees Kenward.

Monty bolts for the door. Kenward rushes after him. And just as Monty takes a step outside --

EXT. PUB - NIGHT

THUNK!!! A CANE CRASHES into Monty's face. He crumples to the ground. He looks up to see Hugo standing over him.

INT. LONDON PUB - NIGHT

Monty sits nursing his bloody nose.

MONTY
You broke my nose!

HUGO
Did I? You caught me off guard. Rushing like that -- you could have been a thief for all I know.

MONTY
(off Kenward's smile)
My barrister won't be amused. I'll have your badge.

Hugo pulls out the vial of cocaine.

HUGO
I'm sure your barrister is aware that possession of cocaine carries a stiff fine and prison sentence. Especially since this isn't your first offense. We're willing to overlook this if you tell us where you were last Wednesday.

MONTY
I was in London, as I told you.

KENWARD
We have a witness who can place you in this very pub.

MONTY
I'll say nothing further until the barrister arrives.

HUGO
You had met Agatha here. You had a heated argument, you were furious with her, were you not?! Then she goes missing soon after.

MONTY
I had nothing to do with her disappearance!!!

HUGO
Then tell us what happened.

Monty looks at them both --

MONTY
She refused to have me set foot in her own house. Her brother, her flesh and blood!

A raucous laugh draws our attention across the pub. The camera pans to --

INT. LONDON PUB - AFTERNOON (MEMORY)

A boisterous crowd surrounds the bar. Monty is the loudest among the bunch.

MONTY (V.O.)
She would only agree to meet in a public place...

Monty turns towards the door. Agatha meets his gaze, then walks towards a table in the back.

BACK OF THE BAR (MEMORY)

Agatha sits at a table. Hugo, unseen by her, watches. She uses a hair pin to nervously carve into the table.

Monty arrives with two drinks in hand. She glares at him, tight-jawed.

MONTY
Come on, join me! We all have vices, Aggie. Some are more acceptable than others, but they slowly destroy us all the same.
(MORE)

MONTY (CONT'D)
(raising his glass)
Hope the writing is going well.

Monty takes a large, cynical gulp.

MONTY (CONT'D)
You finished Curtain yet? Or Are you still staring at a blank page?

AGATHA
Don't be mean.

Beat.

MONTY
I'm in a desperate situation.

AGATHA
It's always a *desperate* situation with you.

MONTY
Agatha, please...

Monty reaches for Agatha's hand.

HUGO
(scoffs)
Mon Dieu.

Monty shoots a look at Hugo. Agatha is unaware of him.

MONTY
I'm alone, Aggie. Madge has turned her back on me. You know how judgy she can be; you're not a good mother and I'm a waste of space. We don't fit the mold.

His words sting but Agatha composes herself.

AGATHA
If you get treatment from a physician - I will give you whatever you ask for.

Monty withdraws his hand.

MONTY
All I need is two hundred pounds. Then I promise you'll never hear from me again.

AGATHA
I can’t help you kill yourself.

She slides a card for a REHAB CLINIC across the table.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
You want support? There it is.
Otherwise... I’m done.

She rises.

MONTY
Agatha, don’t leave. I swear to you,
you’ll regret this!

Agatha exits the pub. The bar patrons stare at Monty.

HUGO (V.O.)
Yes we have witnesses that heard
you threaten her.

INT. LONDON PUB - NIGHT (PRESENT)

Monty looks indignantly at Hugo and Kenward.

MONTY *
Neither of us was well after *
Mothers' death. We dealt with it in *
different ways. *

Monty drags his fingers slowly across the wooden table. The *
scrape is dry — insistent. His hand tightens into a fist. *

The pub noise thins. Monty opens his hand. Dirt spills from *
his palm. *

EXT. CEMETERY, GRAVESIDE - DAY (MEMORY) *

Monty steps forward and lets the soil fall onto the coffin *
below. *

Beneath a brooding sky guests dressed in black trickle away
from the recently filled grave, but Agatha and Monty remain.
Monty cries openly. Agatha clings to his hand, numb. *

MONTY (V.O.)
No matter how broken she was, she
always took care of me.

Hugo watches them from beneath a tree with a bunch of
flowers. He lowers his gaze. At his feet, another grave *
stone. Older, weathered, and not freshly cut like theirs. *

He kneels, brushing away a scatter of leaves with his thumb. *
The name is visible: TERESSA PIETERS - worn but intact. *

Agatha looks towards a pond where a SWAN glides silently.

AGATHA
Swans look peaceful, so elegant. No one sees that they're always moving, always hiding how hard they paddle.

Hugo rises, watches Agatha, not the swan. *

MONTY (V.O.)
She said we were like swans.

INT. LONDON PUB - LATER (PRESENT)

MONTY
I love my sister. I would never cause her harm.

HUGO
You love her money.

Monty stands in protest.

MONTY
That's a lie.

HUGO
Addicts love a good lie.

MONTY
You would know.

Hugo snaps and pushes him very aggressively against the wall. Monty looks frightened.

KENWARD
Pieters!

MONTY
(low, to Hugo)
My sister would be disappointed. You of all people should know, it's the ones you least expect.

This rattles Hugo. Kenward pulls them apart.

Across the bar, Monty's BARRISTER, MR. CHILDRESS has arrived.

MONTY (CONT'D)
Can I go?

KENWARD
We have no evidence to detain you.

Monty walks out nursing his nose, talking to his lawyer who gives Hugo the side eye.

HUGO
(shouting)
I wouldn’t let him take any trips anytime soon.

They leave.

KENWARD
What is wrong with you, man? Why are you so worked up?

HUGO
All these people. Falling over themselves to tear chunks out of her.

KENWARD
You’ve never met the woman.

Hugo's fingers brush the worn wood of the table. Faint, on the surface -- a small, elegant etching of a SWAN.

~~KENWARD~~ (CONT'D) *
~~I told you, there are lines I won’t~~ *
~~cross.~~ *

A heavy silence.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
The desperate are obvious. It's the *
useful ones that worry me. *

Hugo's hand pauses on the swan carving. That's it! *

EXT. STYLES - DAY

SUPER: **SIX MISSING DAYS**

Kenward's car pulls through the gates and closes on a SMALL HOARD OF WAITING REPORTERS.

INT. STYLES / LIBRARY - DAY

Charlotte fidgets in her chair. Hugo paces in front of her.

CHARLOTTE
I was going to see my family in Brighton --

KENWARD
You were instructed no one leave until the investigation is over.

CHARLOTTE
Yes, but it was day trip at most.

Hugo looks at her bags - surely more than just a "day trip."

HUGO
This will only take a moment.
(beat)
What was in that envelope?

KENWARD
What envelope?

CHARLOTTE
I don’t know.

HUGO
Think harder.

CHARLOTTE
Mr. Christie just opened it and instantly threw it in the fire before I could see it.

KENWARD
(to Hugo)
You made no mention of this.

HUGO
Why did you keep it a secret? What did he have over you?

Charlotte gathers herself.

CHARLOTTE
Do you know the real reason she kept inventing characters for me?
(beat)
Because I was disappearing.

HUGO
And you hated her for it.

CHARLOTTE
No, no. I hated myself.

We pan off into:

INT. STYLES / AGATHA'S OFFICE - DAY (MEMORY)

Charlotte searches through Agatha's desk.

CHARLOTTE (V.O.)
She was never going to mentor me.
She was incapable.

She finds the manuscript box and wraps her arms around it.

INT. STYLES / PARLOUR ROOM - DAY (MEMORY)

Charlotte picks up the phone.

CHARLOTTE
Operator, could you connect me to
Bodley Head Publishers in London,
please? Yes, thank you.

Charlotte waits to be connected when --

YELLING from the kitchen. Charlotte looks across.

The doors SWING OPEN. Archie rushes out. Charlotte, shrinks and places the phone down.

A PLATE COMES HURTLING from the kitchen -- it shatters onto the wall, missing Hugo - now standing nearby - by inches.

Agatha comes rushing out after Archie.

AGATHA
I supported this family for years,
and instead of gratitude, you felt
threatened.

ARCHIE
That's enough, Agatha.

AGATHA
I'm sorry I couldn't just stay home
and be the wife to you and the
mother to our child.
(beat)
Can't you understand?
(MORE)

AGATHA (CONT'D)
I wish I could write at my leisure, but I can't -- It takes over and consumes me. Like a constant buzzing in my head that I can only silence when I put pen to paper.

ARCHIE
I'll be back to pack my things while you are at Beverley.

AGATHA
I would do anything to keep our family together. I would stop writing if you asked me to.

ARCHIE
We both know you could never do that.

AGATHA
Archie...

ARCHIE
I'm sorry, Agatha. It's too late. Let's not make this any harder than it is.

He walks away from her.

AGATHA
For Eternity.

Archie stops, not turning. Hugo blanches at the words.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
That's what we said.

ARCHIE
No Agatha. That's what you wrote.

Archie heads for the door, crossing paths with Charlotte without a word. Charlotte runs up to Agatha, who starts to tremble, then crumples to the ground. Hugo can only watch.

AGATHA
First mother, then Monty, and now Archie. Gone.

Charlotte covers her with her arms, and Agatha begins to wail. The outpouring of emotions makes Charlotte cry as well.

CHARLOTTE
You're not alone.

AGATHA
I am.

ROSALIND (O.C.)
He’s leaving because of you!

Agatha looks up and sees Rosalind, eyes red from crying, looking down at her from the staircase.

AGATHA
Darling...

ROSALIND
I hate you! We would be better off without *you!*

Agatha awkwardly makes a move towards Rosalind, but she’s already running up the stairs.

Reeling, Agatha composes herself. She nods in silent agreement with Rosalind.

CHARLOTTE
Agatha...

AGATHA
(broken)
Be a dear and confirm my reservation for Beverley before you go. And tell everyone that under no circumstances should I be disturbed.

Agatha slowly walks away, numb.

INT. STYLES / PARLOUR ROOM - DAY (PRESENT)

KENWARD
He was leaving her?

Charlotte nods, wipes a tear from her eye.

HUGO
Those are crocodile tears, mademoiselle.

Charlotte shakes her head.

HUGO (CONT'D)
You were leaving her also. You went to London to give Lane the manuscript, didn’t you?
(MORE)

HUGO (CONT'D)
You sold all those years of trust to the highest bidder.

Charlotte, frightened, is driven to real tears.

CHARLOTTE
I wanted a job in which I could grow!

Hugo furiously slams his hands on a table.

HUGO
You exploited a desperate woman at her lowest point!

KENWARD
Peiters...

HUGO
(with disdain)
We're done here.

EXT. STYLES - DAY

Kenward follows Hugo to the car, both visibly irked.

HUGO
I should have told you.

KENWARD
You intentionally withheld an important piece of evidence from me. How can I trust you?

HUGO
Maybe you can’t.

KENWARD
Can we just finish this case before I lose my patience, or my job.

They get into the car. Kenward notices that Hugo is breaking into a sweat.

HUGO
He'll be at the country club. Men like Mr. Christie seldom wander far from their comforts.

Hugo instinctively reaches into his breast pocket for his prescription bottle. He realizes he doesn’t have it.

IN THE SIDE MIRROR: Hugo sees Teresa, left behind.

EXT. SUNNINGDALE GOLF CLUB - DAY - ESTABLISHING

A sprawling GOLF CLUB ESTATE. A CREST above the main gates, Hugo and Kenward walk through a throng of reporters.

REPORTER #1
Constable! Are there any new leads?

KENWARD
Excuse us, please.

REPORTER #2
Are you here to question Mr. Christie?

HUGO
Pardon, gentlemen. We have no comment! Merci

REPORTER #2
(under his breath)
Froggie bugger.

Hugo turns to the reporters, about to reply --

KENWARD
That's "Belgian bugger" to you!

Hugo smiles at him as they approach the MAIN BUILDING.

REPORTER #1 (O.C.)
Mr. Christie! Is it true that your wife had a history of mental breakdowns?

Hugo and Kenward turn to see --

The reporters now chasing a MAN covered in a coat and surrounded by club employees.

REPORTER #2
Did you have anything to do with your wife's disappearance?

REPORTER #3
Mr. Christie, with your wife missing, why are you here playing golf?

The reporters are stunned and silent by the blunt question.

HUGO
(to Kenward)
Well, that's a good question.

Archie climbs into a GOLF CART and heads off with reporters chasing it out across the green. Kenward walks towards it, but Hugo holds him back.

HUGO (CONT'D)
That wasn't Archie.

Hugo motions Kenward inside.

INT. GOLF CLUB / MAIN BUILDING - DAY

Hugo scans for Archie as he walks past reception.

KENWARD
How do you know?

HUGO
That man used his left hand to hold the jacket over his head and enter the golf cart. Mr. Christie is right-handed.

They pass A LARGE WALL DISPLAY CASE. A collection of trophies and PHOTOS of players, many are GOLF TEAMS & COUPLES.

Hugo freezes. He removes the CHARRED PHOTO from his inside coat pocket.

ON THE PHOTO: A SCORCHED CREST - the golf club crest. Realization hits. Hugo scans the contents of the case.

KENWARD
What are you doing?

Hugo stops and places the photo on the glass case.

HUGO
Eggs, mon ami! Matching eggs.

The same photo is in the case, but the woman is now revealed--

A WAVE OF ANGER flashes on Hugo's face. He feels the glass with his hands, tests its strength.

KENWARD
No, you can't possibly --

Hugo BALLS HIS FIST, and, with a ferocious, animalistic SNARL, he SLAMS his fist, breaking the glass. Shards scatter. Hugo's fist bleeds, dripping on the floor.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
Are you mad?! I can arrest you for vandalizing property.

Ignoring the pain, Hugo grabs the picture from the case.

HUGO
Do what you must.

Kenward's unsure what to do. He takes out a handkerchief and wraps it around Hugo's bleeding fist. Hugo is taken aback.

THE CLUB MANAGER steps out of his office, seeing what has happened--

MANAGER
Security! Someone call the police!

KENWARD
(We're the police!) We can't just leave. *

HUGO
We absolutely can. (Run!) *

EXT. GOLF CLUB COURTYARD - MOMENTS LATER

Hugo and Kenward speed-walk across a courtyard, hats lowered over their faces.

Hugo suddenly stops, having seen something. He changes tack.

KENWARD
For heaven's sake!

INT. CLUBHOUSE LOUNGE - CONTINUOUS

Nan sits by a patio window doing a CRYPTIC CROSSWORD.

Hugo appears and SLAMS the bloodied picture against the glass. A startled Nan, looks at the PHOTO - an inscription at the bottom reads:

1926 Tournament Champions, Nan Watts, George Kon, Archie Christie, Nancy Neele.

She looks around nervously, then opens the patio door.

HUGO
Why didn't you tell us about Nancy Neele when we first spoke?

NAN
Because Agatha is my dearest friend and she's a very private woman.

HUGO
If you knew something that could have helped her, then you chose silence.

NAN
Because, I am responsible.

She turns away and closes her eyes in shame.

AGATHA (O.S.)
If I could have just one uninterrupted afternoon, Nan..

INT. CLUBHOUSE LOUNGE - AFTERNOON (MEMORY)

Nan opens her eyes to see Agatha, opposite her at a table. Agatha can barely keep still - her fingers tap against her teacup. Beside her, a neat stack of manuscript pages peeks from a folder.

AGATHA
I could finish it. The ending’s all there -- I can see it in my mind.

NAN
Then you shall have it. I’ve brought along a friend to join us on the course. You can stay right here and work.

Agatha’s eyes brighten instantly.

AGATHA
Nan, you know me better than anyone!

She takes the pages out.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
Anyway, I would just be a bore and let’s be honest, I’ve never seen the appeal of knocking things about for sport. It’s a gift, being so easily entertained.

Nan masks her annoyance with a smile.

INT. CLUBHOUSE LOUNGE (PRESENT)

NAN
Agatha detested golf, she wrote a novel where someone was murdered and buried on a golf course.
(beat)
I knew Nancy from bridge club. She's a huge fan of Agatha's work. And a keen golfer. I was doing Agatha a kindness.

HUGO
Some kindnesses have very long shadows.

INT. CLUBHOUSE LOUNGE - AFTERNOON (MEMORY)

Agatha sits at her table, writing, glancing up briefly to look out of the window, she sees the foursome -- George, Archie, Nan, and a new young lady NANCY NEELE -- setting off across the green.

Nancy laughs at something Archie says. His hand brushes her elbow as he guides her to the next tee. Then Archie turns and Nancy's smile drops.

Nan sees all this, looks across to Agatha, who lowers her gaze back to her notebook.

INT. CLUBHOUSE LOUNGE (PRESENT)

Nan is becoming flustered.

NAN
I wasn't thinking properly.

GEORGE (O.S.)
What is the meaning of this!

George has entered the lounge.

KENWARD
Stay where you are, sir. We're just asking a few questions.

GEORGE
I will not. How dare you accost my wife.

KENWARD
No one is accosting anyone.

Kenward blocks George from getting to Hugo.

HUGO
Why didn’t you say anything? She had to figure it out herself, didn't she?

INT. CLUBHOUSE LOUNGE - MORNING (MEMORY)

A waiter approaches Agatha’s table with a folded newspaper. She lays it beside her: a photograph from the club tournament -- Archie, arm snug around Nancy’s waist, Nan and George flanking them. An intimacy casual enough to go unnoticed -- unless you’re looking.

Agatha zeroes in on the details of the photo. Her face barely betraying the wave of emotions rising inside.

FLASH TO:

Agatha reads from her CURTAIN MANUSCRIPT.

AGATHA
My indications will lead you to the truth. And perhaps, then, you would wish that they had not led you so far. You would say instead: 'Ring down the curtain.”

INT. GOLF CLUB LOUNGE - DAY (PRESENT)

George breaks through and pushes Hugo backwards.

GEORGE
You need to leave and stop this nonsense immediately.

Hugo ignores George’s threats.

HUGO
Where is she?

NAN
I don't know, you're the one we're paying to find her.

HUGO
Not Agatha, Nancy Neele!

GEORGE
Don't answer them, darling.

Nan hesitates, then--

NAN
'Genuflect to fly south for the winter'.

KENWARD
What?

Nan lifts the CROSSWORD that she's been doing from the table.

NAN
It's the last one on this dastardly cryptic and I just can't get it.

MANAGER (O.S.)
OVER THERE!

The Manager and TWO SECURITY GUARDS have entered the far side of the lounge.

HUGO
We shall reconvene.

Kenward and Hugo take off across the courtyard.

The security guards follow, negotiating the lounge chairs and clientele slowly and politely.

BACK OF THE COUNTRY CLUB

KENWARD
They'll have my badge for this.

HUGO
One problem at a time, Kenward!
There's a new suspect on the loose.

Hugo and Kenward round the corner just in time to see --

Archie climbing into a car, he extends his RIGHT HAND to lift a final SUITCASE inside.

Archie sees Hugo. Their eyes meet. Hugo rushes towards him, gets his foot in the car door before it closes, pulls Archie out.

Inside, a WOMAN hides beneath Archie's coat.

ARCHIE
Unhand me!
(to the driver)
Go!

The car drives away. Kenward arrives.

HUGO
You were leaving Agatha!

KENWARD
Hugo, stop.

HUGO (CONT'D)
You were having an affair and you didn’t want anyone to know about it.

ARCHIE
How dare you? You are fired!
(to Kenward)
And you, I will have your job for this, you half-wit, incompetent, sorry excuse for a man.

Kenward seethes and lunges. Hugo pushes Kenward back, then steps up and THROWS A WICKED PUNCH, with his uninjured hand, landing squarely on Archie’s face.

BULBS FLASH. Hugo and Kenward turn to see reporters a step behind them, taking photos of Archie on the ground.

KENWARD
Oh God.

HUGO
Now run.

Kenward hesitates, but follows.

INT. KENWARD’S CAR - DAY

Kenward and Hugo jump into the car. In the rear view, the Security Officers scramble after them, blowing whistles. Hugo sees George rushing to HIS CAR, Nan trailing behind him.

KENWARD
We are crossing lines left, right, and center, Pieters, and I’m not at all happy about it!

Kenward speeds away.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
And I didn’t need your help back there.

HUGO
You’re quite welcome.

Kenward sees Hugo's bloody knuckles, takes out another handkerchief and hands it to Hugo who wraps his other hand - a matching set.

KENWARD
I'm running out of handkerchiefs. Did you catch a glimpse? Was it the woman in the picture?

HUGO
I'd put money on it.

KENWARD
We have to find her. Did you see the luggage in the car? If she slips through our fingers now, odds are we'll never find her.

HUGO
(realizing)
Luggage...

Hugo looks around the car and finds a newspaper.

KENWARD
What are you doing?

With hankerchief-ed hands Hugo flips to the travel section.

CLOSE ON AN AD for an IMPERIAL AIRWAYS flight to Paris.

HUGO
Genuflect; Neale. She's about to fly south for the winter.

EXT. AERODROME - DAY

- PROPELLERS turn.

- CHOCKS are pulled from beneath wheels.

- A small PASSENGER PLANE rolls down the airstrip.

Nancy Neele looks out of a window demurely, then--

A CAR HORN BLARES. Kenward's car speeds into her view and pulls alongside the plane, honking wildly.

BACK TO NANCY. She sighs gently as the plane slows and pulls to a stop.

INT. HANGAR - A LITTLE LATER

Nancy sits in the light that streams through the hangar doors surrounded by luggage and hat boxes. A STEWARD hands her a glass of Champagne. She raises it.

NANCY
To Paris... I wondered how long it would take you. Archie always did overestimate himself.

Hugo and Kenward take a seat opposite her.

HUGO
You do realize that you're a suspect and you can't just leave.

NANCY
I see. Well, now that's cleared up, how may I regain my good standing with you, Detective?

HUGO
You can begin by telling us about your relationship with Mr. Christie.

NANCY
It must be obvious if you're here.
(beat)
I had nothing to do with her disappearance. More than likely, she's hiding somewhere, having a good laugh at everyone's expense, gaining notoriety and publicity for her next book. I heard they're covering this story in America. Barely anyone has heard of her beyond England before this. It's brilliant, really...

KENWARD
You two were acquaintances.

NANCY
Not really. I was a great admirer of her work.
(she sips)
You can judge me, but I'm not the married one. The heart wants what it wants, no matter how wrong it may seem.

HUGO
When was the last time you saw her?

NANCY
The day before she disappeared. She followed me, into the city.

She turns as if she's seen someone, and we're in--

EXT. / INT. LONDON ARCADE - DAY (MEMORY)

Nancy has spotted Agatha, between the heads of shoppers, staring at her. Agatha snaps a photo with her pocket camera.

Nancy turns and walks briskly away. She looks over her shoulder now and then, seeing Agatha weave in and out of the crowd, stalking her. Growing nervous, her pace quickens. Nancy opens her umbrella and walks out into the rain --

EXT. LONDON STREET - DAY (MEMORY)

Nancy takes one final look back, but doesn't see her. She relaxes and turns forward --

Agatha stands in front of her without an umbrella, getting drenched, hands balled into fists.

NANCY
Agatha?
(off Agatha’s silence)
Does Archie know you’re here?

Agatha simply stares. Musters to keep herself steady.

NANCY (CONT'D)
Agatha, you're drenched. You have to get out of the rain.

AGATHA
I will give you whatever you want. The proceeds from my next five books.

NANCY
Agatha...

AGATHA
I’ve had everything taken away from me. It’s all I have left. My writing and my family. Give Archie back to me.

NANCY
Archie isn’t mine to give or take.

AGATHA
I’ll never grant him a divorce.

Nancy looks at her, appalled.

NANCY (V.O.)
And then she stormed away. That was the last I saw of her.

INT. HANGAR - DAY (PRESENT)

HUGO
Were you with Archie during the night of Agatha’s disappearance?

NANCY
Yes, I joined him at his friends’ home for a golfing weekend.

KENWARD
Convenient.

HUGO
If something were to happen to Mrs. Christie, Archie would inherit every penny. A divorce guarantees nothing. Especially after an affair.

Nancy’s smile flickers, just for a heartbeat.

The sound of CARS ENGINE breaks the moment. Between the hangar doors A GROUP OF VEHICLES screeches to a halt. Nancy glances out, finishes her champagne in one elegant swallow.

NANCY
This is not merely an affair. We’re in love. Archie wants to leave her and start a new life with me.

HUGO
And maybe he saw only one way to be with you.

Nancy looks at Hugo with a grim expression.

A GROUP OF MEN led by Highsmith steps into the hangar.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Chief Inspector Highsmith.

KENWARD
Are you here for Ms. Neele?

Highsmith sighs.

HUGO
He's here for us.

INT. INTERPOL OFFICES -- DAY

Hugo and Kenward sit opposite Childress who is mid-rant. Monty slouches in his chair, Archie next to him with a bruised and swollen eye. Highsmith watches them all, arms folded.

SUPER: **SEVEN MISSING DAYS**

CHILDRESS
Assault, vandalism of private property, police harassment...

Hugo scoffs.

ARCHIE
My family has been hounded by both of you. My name dragged through the mud. The press is accusing me of my wife’s murder, and you two have done absolutely nothing to find her!

CHILDRESS
Before it gets further out of hand, we’ve spoken to the Chief Constable...

MONTY
A family friend.

CHILDRESS
... and demanded Scotland Yard take over your laughable investigation. We can’t afford to lose any more valuable time in finding Mrs. Christie. You’ve proven to be ineffectual, not to mention spearheading the costliest police search to date.

ARCHIE
My wife is missing, we give you money to find her, and instead you harass me, my brother-in-law, my friends...

HUGO
Your precious Nancy Neele.

ARCHIE
You leave her out of this.

HUGO
It’s a clear motive. You were having an affair with Ms. Neele.

ARCHIE
Agatha and I agreed to divorce.

HUGO
That's not what Ms. Neele told us.

HIGHSMITH
That’s enough, Pieters. Effective immediately, you are officially terminated. Clean out your office, and I will need your badge. I’m sorry, but it’s beyond my control.
(beat)
I'd hoped that you were ready. Perhaps I let my emotions cloud my judgment.

Highsmith doesn’t like this one bit. He takes out a REPORT and places it on the table. Hugo reads.

HIGHSMITH (CONT'D)
A report that verifies, with eye witness accounts from members of our own constabulary, that you have been acting under the influence of opioids while on duty.

Hugo’s eyes dart up towards Kenward who avoids his gaze.

HIGHSMITH (CONT'D)
Constable Kenward is an honest officer. He’s just doing his job.

Kenward pointedly stands and leaves.

Hugo stares into space.

EXT. INTERPOL OFFICE - DAY

Hugo walks out of Interpol with a meager box of his belongings. IN THE DISTANCE, he sees Archie, Monty, and Childress wading through the sea of boisterous reporters.

REPORTER #1
Mr. Christie!!! Can you confirm or deny rumors about an affair?

REPORTER #2
Did your wife learn of the affair?

REPORTER #3
Did you murder your wife!!!

ARCHIE
Questions will be answered when I grant an exclusive interview to the Daily Mail this evening. Good day.

CHILDRESS
Thank you, everyone.

Childress leads Archie and Monty into a car. Hugo watches them leave, then looks into his box. A PHOTOGRAPH of his wife TERESA smiles back at him. Shaking off the pang of pain, Hugo disappears into the crowd.

INT. LONDON PUB - THE NEXT DAY

SUPER: **EIGHT MISSING DAYS**

Hugo, disheveled and intoxicated, nurses a glass of wine at the bar.

A patron nearby leaves. Hugo sees a folded newspaper left behind. He unfolds it --

THE DAILY MAIL

On the front page, a picture of Agatha and Archie, and the caption: *MRS. CHRISTIE FEARED DEAD, HUSBAND'S STATEMENT TO THE DAILY MAIL*

EXT. LONDON - DAY

Archie wades through a barrage of Reporters, Photographers, and ANGRY ONLOOKERS, who yell "MURDERER!" at the top of their lungs.

ARCHIE
(directly to camera)
...my wife had discussed the possibility of disappearing at will. Some time ago, she told her sister,

A FLASH: AGATHA MOUTHS THE WORDS AS ARCHIE SPEAKS

ARCHIE (V.O.)
'I could disappear if I wished to and set about it properly.'

INT. MADGE'S HOME - PARLOUR ROOM - DAY

Madge chain smokes as she reads the interview.

MADGE
(to camera)
She certainly did no such thing...

ARCHIE (V.O.)
... That shows that the possibility of engineering a disappearance had been running through her mind...

INT. CAR - DAY

Highsmith reads the article as he is driven to work.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
... You see, there are three possible explanations of her disappearance: voluntary, loss of memory... and suicide.

He shares a look to camera.

A FLASH: AGATHA HOLDS A GUN TO HER HEAD

INT. PUBLISHER'S OFFICE - DAY

Lane reads with a phone to his ear.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
... I do not believe this is a case of suicide. She never threatened suicide...

LANE
(to camera)
I wouldn’t put it past her.
(into phone)
Yes, I'm listening.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
... but if she did contemplate that, I am sure her mind would turn to poison, but that she used poison largely in her stories.

A FLASH: AGATHA CONTEMPLATES A VIAL OF LIQUID.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - DAY

A run-down room. A disheveled Monty is passed out on top of the newspaper.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
But against the theory of suicide... if a person intends to end her life, she does not take the trouble to go miles away...

A FLASH: AGATHA OUT OF BREATH, WALKS THROUGH DARKNESS

INT. STYLES / LIBRARY - DAY

The servants gather around reading the paper.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
... walk down the hill and off -- to God knows where, before doing it. I suggest she walked downhill because she always hated walking uphill.

HOUSEKEEPER
Any exercise, really...

The Butler scolds the Housekeeper with a look.

INT. KENWARD’S HOME - DAY

Kenward sits miserably in his armchair reading the article. Kenward's WIFE puts a supportive hand on his shoulder.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
I left home at 9:15 a.m. in the ordinary way, and that was the last time I saw my wife. In the afternoon, she went into the city.

A FLASH: AGATHA, BEDRAGGLED, RAIN RUNNING DOWN HER FACE

ARCHIE (V.O.)
She returned here in time for dinner, which she took alone.

EXT. GOLF CLUB - DAY

Nan reads the paper on the green.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
I do not know what happened after that; I only know that she got into such a state that she could not sit down to read or work. She took the car and left...

A FLASH: AGATHA DRIVES.

EXT. STYLES - GARDEN - DAY

Charlotte reads the paper as Rosalind plays in the garden.

ARCHIE (V.O.)
It is absolutely untrue to suggest that there was anything in the nature of a row or tiff between my wife and me on Friday morning. She was perfectly well...

A FLASH: AGATHA NUMB, WATCHING ARCHIE LEAVE

INT. LONDON MUSEUM -DAY

Nancy sits in front of René Magritte's "This Is Not a Pipe".

ARCHIE (V.O.)
I strongly deprecate introducing any tittle-tattle into this matter. That will not help me find my wife, and that is all I want to do.

Nancy sets the paper down.

INT. LONDON PUB - DAY

Hugo places the newspaper down and drinks his wine in a gulp, then waves to the BARTENDER, who brings a bottle and pours him another glass.

BARTENDER
Anything else, sir?

Hugo takes one last look at the newspaper, then --

HUGO
Leave the bottle.

EXT. PUB - NIGHT

Hugo holding his wine bottle, stumbles into the street, bumping into a GROUP OF MEN. Hugo mumbles an apology, and turns into another THUG.

THUG #1
Where d'you think you're going.

The other men come up behind Hugo, surrounding him. Sensing an ambush -- he breaks his wine bottle on the wall, forming a weapon. He swipes in vain but The Thugs disarm him, hold him up against the wall and start beating him.

THUG #1 (CONT'D)
You need to mind your business,
Frenchie?

HUGO
For the last time, I'm --

A FIST connects to Hugo's jaw, and he crumples to the ground. The Thugs deliver vicious kicks to Hugo.

THUG #1
Go near the Christies again and
we'll be back to finish the job.

And then everything goes BLACK.

INT. HUGO'S APARTMENT - DAY

SUPER: **NINE MISSING DAYS**

The thinest ray of sun peeks through the drawn drapes. Hugo slowly wakes as a LOUD BANGING comes from the door. He nurses a black eye and a split lip.

KENWARD (O.S.)
Detective Pieters? It's Constable Kenward. Are you in?
(more knocking)
Detective! Answer the door, please.

Hugo doesn't stir. Outside in the hall, he hears Kenward's footsteps leaving. Hugo remains on the floor and sees a PHOTOGRAPH of his wife, TERESA, spilled from his tipped-over box. She seems to stare at him.

His hand TREMBLES as he scrambles to find an old pill bottle, shakes it -- EMPTY.

INT. CHEMIST'S - DAY

Hugo, barely put together, stands at the counter. Hugo puts cash down. The chemist eyeballs the money --

CHEMIST
It seems that your prescription has expired.

Hugo puts more down.

CHEMIST (CONT'D)
I may be able to help you...

Hugo puts the rest of his money in the pile, and the chemist takes out a bottle.

EXT. PHARMACY - CONTINUOUS

Hugo, riddled with sweat, ducks into an alley.

He grits through the pain and struggles to open the bottle, spilling cubes on the ground. He gets on all fours, desperately scooping them up as pedestrians pass by, looking down at him with pity.

Hugo glances up as Teresa walks by. Concerned.

He downs a handful of pills and sits against the wall.

INT. OFF LICENSE - NIGHT

SUPER: **TEN MISSING DAYS**

High on medication, Hugo stumbles down the aisle. He looks down--

AGATHA'S DEAD BODY LIES FACE DOWN ON THE FLOOR

He steps over her drops a handful of coins and bills on the counter for the befuddled clerk --

HUGO
Whatever I can get with this...

On the counter: AGATHA'S PHOTO on the front cover of a newspaper. While the clerk fetches the bottle of wine, Hugo swipes the newspaper and hides it in his coat.

EXT. ALLEY - NIGHT

Hugo sits on a stoop clutching his pocket-watch between his fingers. He finishes off the bottle of wine, tosses the bottle aside. He climbs the stoop steps, stumbles then sprawls to the ground. He resigns himself to the ground. His eyes begin to droop --

He looks up to see Teresa looking down at him with a supportive smile.

HUGO
I'm done.

Teresa is now Agatha, and she reaches down.

AGATHA
No, you're not. Wake up...

He doesn't move --

AGATHA (CONT'D)
Wake up!!

FADE TO BLACK:

KENWARD (O.S.)
Wake up, Pieters!

EXT. ALLEY - DAY

Hugo opens his eyes to find himself in the same alley by his apartment that Nan found him in. He sleeps among the vegetable castoffs. The newspaper lies next to him - headlines read, **CHRISTIE FEARED DEAD!**

SUPER: **ELEVEN MISSING DAYS**

Kenward struggles to lift him to his feet.

KENWARD
Give me your arm.

Hugo pushes him away and falls back down.

HUGO
Leave me be.

KENWARD
I've been calling for days, and not one word from you. I'm not a man prone to hysterics, but you had me worried. Now, will you please get up?

HUGO
I'm fine down here. My keys..?

KENWARD
Oh, you mean these?

Kenward holds up a key ring.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
It was right at your feet -- next to the rotting cabbage.
(beat)
Well, if you're not getting up, I will join you down there.

Hugo looks at Kenward quizzically. Kenward lies down in the rotting vegetable next to him.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
That stench...
(beat)
They made me sign the report.

HUGO
You don't have to --

KENWARD
I do. Because I've got a wife, two children, and a mortgage that doesn't forgive bravery.

Hugo painfully starts to get up.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
What are you doing?

HUGO
I despise apologies.

He reaches out to Kenward, who helps him to his feet.

INT. HUGO'S APARTMENT - DAY

Kenward pours tea. Hugo holds a cold cloth to his head.

KENWARD
Drink this.

Hugo takes a sip. Kenward picks up strewn LETTERS from the floor and returns them to their box. He lifts a photo of Teressa.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
Highsmith told me everything.

Hugo looks at Teresa's photo --

HUGO
We were refugees. I went back to *
fight. Her letters kept me alive. I *
read them until the paper thinned. *
She didn't tell me she was dying. *
I thought I was racing toward her. *
But I was too late. *

KENWARD
I'm sorry for your loss. I don't mean to dredge up the past.

HUGO
It's not the past mon ami. It's my every day. I've let her down. I've lost the case, my job -- my way.

KENWARD
And what would she think seeing you like this?
(beat)
She'd think I've been a poor excuse for a partner, letting you give up on yourself.

Hugo looks up - the first time he's heard the word "partner."

KENWARD (CONT'D)
You're the most observant, diligent person I know. You have an uncanny talent for deduction, and you're relentless to the point of being incredibly annoying. That is the only you I know.

Kenward stands, gathers his coat.

KENWARD (CONT'D)
I’ve got some business to attend to. Now, for god’s sake, take a shower.

Kenward leaves. Hugo slumps forward on to his desk. His head lands on last night's newspaper.

CLOSE POV: the words 'TERESA NEELE' come into focus--

HUGO
Teresa Neele?

Hugo picks up the paper. An advert in the Personals reads:

*“Maligned **seeker of truth**, and relative of **Teresa Neele, give me a Ring** or simply visit 87 Brompton Rd. **Pour l’éternité.**”*

Hugo reels, looks back at the words '***seeker of truth***'.

He scrabbles around for his copy of *THE MURDER OF ROGER ACKROYD,* finds the the line underlined -- begins to mouth it silently.

"The truth, however ugly in itself, is always beautiful to seekers after it."

Hugo has a realization, rushes to a cupboard and pulls out an old box of files. He drags it out into the room and tosses papers here and there until he finds -- A NEWSPAPER ARTICLE.

He gazes at his own picture. The deadline reads: **DETECTIVE UNRAVELS IMPOSSIBLE MYSTERY.**

He scans the article and sees a direct quote from him --

Peiters remarked, "The truth, however ugly in itself, is always beautiful to seekers after it."

A camera flashes. He looks up and he is in--

INT. PRESS ROOM - DAY (MEMORY)

Hugo stands in front of a crowded group of reporters.

HUGO
The truth, however ugly in itself, is always beautiful to seekers after it.

Hugo looks at the back of the room, where he now sees Agatha for the first time, having just taken his photo. Their eyes meet for a beat.

BACK IN THE PRESENT

Hugo scrambles to his keepsake box. He flips through it and pulls out --

A PHOTO: Teresa sitting on a bench. A nurse sits on a bench next to her -- It's a YOUNG AGATHA. In the corner a hand-written label reads, ***Torquay, England, 1917***

Hugo retrieves a stack of LETTERS. He pulls out several from their envelopes. Letters dated from the War. Hugo feels the heavy quality of the paper.

Then he holds the paper to the sunlight. It REVEALS -- the faded EMBOSSED IMAGE OF A SWAN!

He begins to read the letter. WE SEE GLIMPSES OF WORDS: *TO MY BELOVED...*

His eyes land on the closing section: *Pour l'éternité.* Hugo's eyes go wide.

INT. HUGO'S APARTMENT, SHOWER - MOMENTS LATER

Hugo, head lowered, as a rush of hot water washes over him.

INT. HUGO'S APARTMENT, BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Hugo, at the sink, takes a pair of scissors and urgently starts to shear off his long scraggly beard.

EXT. BROMPTON ROAD - DAY

Hugo, in a neatly pressed suit and a carefully groomed handlebar mustache, bears an uncanny resemblance to Agatha's fictional Belgian detective.

He weaves between CHRISTMAS SHOPPERS with new urgency as he checks the address from the advert and then quickly heads towards the JEWELRY STORE we saw Agatha exit earlier. A choir sings 'O Come All Ye Faithful'.

INT. JEWELRY SHOP - DAY

Hugo waits at the display case.

CLERK
May I help you, sir?

HUGO
(hurried)
Yes, I'm here to pick up an order for Teresa Neele. I am her husband.

The clerk pulls out the registry.

HUGO (CONT'D)
I'm in a bit of a rush --

CLERK
Here it is! An inscription for her wedding ring.

The clerk hands a ring box to Hugo then turns to write a receipt --

Hugo inspects the ring. Inscribed on the outside are the words: ***The Swan Hotel.*** *

CLERK (CONT'D)
And how will you be paying?

The clerk looks up -- Hugo and the ring are both gone.

INT. TRAIN STATION - DAY

Hugo uses the station's phone.

HUGO
Constable Kenward please, yes it's urgent.

The train whistle blares through the station.

EXT. TRAIN STATION - TRACKS - DAY

A porter yells for final boarding. Hugo runs through clouds of smoke to make the train just as the door closes. The train pulls away.

EXT. HARROGATE STATION - LATER

Hugo gets off the train. He runs towards waiting taxis.

EXT. THE SWAN HOTEL - DAY

Hugo’s taxi pulls into the turning circle of a WELLNESS RETREAT.

It has the aire of a sanatorium.

Hugo gets out and pays the driver. After the taxi leaves, he sees a woman on the street hail his cab.

While he can't see her face, Hugo sees her FUR COAT: the one Agatha went missing in. She climbs in and speeds away.

Hugo urgently waves a horse-drawn cab entering the circle.

EXT. ROAD, HARROGATE - MOMENTS LATER

The taxi speeds down the road. A slow car turns into the road, forcing the pursuing cab to slow, but it swerves and follows.

THE TRAIN STATION

The taxi stops and Agatha's fur-coated figure gets out, heading for the departing train.

TRAIN PLATFORM

Agatha’s hat bobs in and out of view on the crowded platform.

PURSUING POV - chasing Agatha rushing down the train car --

SUDDENLY, a hand grabs her shoulder. Agatha spins around and we discover that it's not Agatha at all -- IT'S NAN WATTS.

CUT to reveal that our PURSUER is not Hugo but Constable Kenward. Nan looks at him, caught!

FLASH: Agatha reads from MYSTERIOUS AFFAIR AT STYLES.

AGATHA
Every murderer is probably somebody's old friend. You cannot mix up sentiment and reason.

EXT. THE SWAN HOTEL - DAY (FLASHBACK)

We now see that Hugo catches a glimpse of the fur-coated woman's shoes: red brogues as she steps into the cab. When the cab speeds away, Hugo turns to hail his cab.

One swerves towards him. The door swings open. Inside, Kenward is about to get out...

HUGO
Don't let her get away!

Kenward's cab drives in pursuit. Hugo heads into the Hotel.

INT. HOTEL HALLWAY - DAY

Hugo passes rooms. In one, a GROUP OF WOMEN sitting in a circle look up at him with blank expressions. In another room full of EQUIPMENT with straps, A WOMAN stares out of a window.

INT. HOTEL STAIRS - DAY

Hugo races up the stairs.

INT. CORRIDOR - DAY

Hugo approaches Room 6.

INT. AGATHA'S ROOM - DAY

Dark, quiet and still. From the other side of the door, POUNDING.

HUGO (O.S.)
Madame Christie? I know you're in there. Please open the door!

More FRANTIC POUNDING.

HUGO (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Madame Christie, open the door now!

After a quiet moment, the door is VIOLENTLY KICKED OPEN. Hugo rushes in and his face FALLS --

Sprawled on the ground is Agatha Christie’s lifeless body.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. THE SWAN HOTEL, POND - LATER

Hugo, opens his eyes. He stares across the water and exhales slowly.

Then he opens his pill bottle and EMPTIES it into the pond. The pills disrupt the surface and in his fractured reflection he catches glimpses of Teresa, until she is gone.

He turns and we follow him up the step, growing straighter and taller as he walks into--

INT. THE SWAN HOTEL - SPA / SANATORIUM - LATER

Hugo, in his smart suit and slicked-back hair, stoically enters into the spa room, which is now filled with familiar faces --

Archie, Madge, Monty, Lane, George and Charlotte all clamor when they see Hugo.

ARCHIE
What is the meaning of this?! You are far, far out of your depth, Pieters. I don't know what weird twisted game you are playing, but we will press charges. Charlotte, go to the front desk and call Inspector Highsmith immediately.

HUGO
Don't worry, sir. Inspector Highsmith is already on his way.

ARCHIE
Well. Good.

MADGE
Do you have news of Agatha? Is that why we're here. I can see it in your face. What's happened to her?

LANE
Why am I here?

MONTY
Why are any of us here, Lane?

GEORGE
And where is my wife? I was told she was here?

ARCHIE
Will someone explain what on earth is happening here?!! Constable Kenward have you lost your mind?!

KENWARD
Everyone, please calm down.

HUGO
Patience, Mr. Christie. It is painfully obvious that I've discovered the truth behind your wife's disappearance and gathered you all here to reveal what has occurred.

ARCHIE
I'm not staying for this ridiculous charade.

HUGO
The least you can do is grant a few minutes of your precious time before the police arrive. I'm sure you'll manage to squeeze a round of golf in before the day is done.

Archie sits down. Hugo stands in the middle of the room.

HUGO (CONT'D)
What truly happened to Agatha Christie?

Hugo looks around the room, lands on Monty.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Was she murdered by her drug-addicted, ne'er-do-well brother...

CLOSE on Monty who scoffs, as he struggles with sobriety, riddled with sweat.

HUGO (CONT'D)
You were bleeding money, burning bridges, and Agatha held the purse strings. She said she'd help you if you got clean, but the drugs always come first don't they, Monty? Desperation kept you on my trail, following my every move. Could it have pushed you further? One sharp argument on a dark night, and you might have decided to end the problem and claim your inheritance in one stroke.

MONTY
You don't know what you're talking about.

HUGO
How about her vengeful publisher...

CLOSE on Mr. Lane.

HUGO (CONT'D)
... whose empire was crumbling. You feared she'd leave for another house. You wanted the Poirot novel she was writing, and you didn't care how you got it -- flattery, manipulation, even theft. And if she died? Well, you already had the book jackets ready.

Charlotte's frayed nerves make her nauseated.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Or Mademoiselle Fisher - the assistant who wanted to be the next Agatha Christie. You dreamed of fame, but did your pages ever match your ambition? The mentorship soured, bitterness grew, and so did your interest in her most valuable possession --

Hugo pulls out the CURTAIN MANUSCRIPT. Mr. Lane bolts upright.

LANE
You stole that!

HUGO
Did I? From whom, sir?

Mr. Lane takes a deep breath and becomes tight-lipped.

CLOSE on Archie.

HUGO (CONT'D)
But then, we have to ask ourselves, was she murdered by an adulterous husband desperate for a divorce. If Agatha were gone, you'd keep the estate, the money, the sympathy. No court, no headlines, just freedom, paid for in blood.

ARCHIE
This is a farce.

Family members look at Archie with scorn. Archie tries to leave - Kenward blocks him.

HUGO
But that would be so expected, so boring, so... ORDINARY.
(beat)
While your actions may have been despicable, there's someone left whose betrayal would completely destroy Agatha.

Behind Hugo, Kenward escorts Nan into the room.

GEORGE
Nan? Where have you been I've been worried sick. I've a mind to...

NAN
Please, just be quiet, George!

George realizes something is off and quietens.

HUGO
Her best friend since childhood, who stayed close, smiled sweetly, always in her shadow, until you introduced the girl who would become her replacement. You fed the affair, and then you watched on as Agatha's life was torn apart, page by page. This time, <u>you</u> would be the shoulder to cry on.

Nan cast her eyes down.

EXT. STYLES - NIGHT (MEMORY)

Agatha drives her car into the night.

HUGO (V.O.)
On the night in question, betrayed, tormented and judged, she discovers her manuscript, her final Poirot novel, is missing. At this, her lowest ebb, in desperation, she drives...

EXT. ROAD - NEWLANDS CORNER - NIGHT (MEMORY)

Agatha shields her eyes as BRIGHT LIGHTS from an oncoming car blind her. She swerves, just missing another vehicle that brushes roadside shrubs, avoiding a catastrophic crash.

HUGO (V.O.)
But she wasn’t alone that night.

Agatha pulls over and gets out of her car. A FIGURE IN SHADOW climbs out of the other car. Agatha steps back, nervous.

The FIGURE steps into MOONLIGHT -- Nan.

HUGO (V.O.)
None other than her closest confidante.

Nan runs to Agatha.

NAN
Are you alright?

Agatha nods. They inspect her car - the HEADLIGHT IS BROKEN.

HUGO (V.O.)
This explains the glass I found at the scene.

FLASH TO -

Hugo steps on the track and CRACK! He bends down and fishes a piece of glass buried in the dirt.

INT. BALLROOM - DAY (PRESENT)

HUGO
If this scenario is true, then her confidante would have a broken headlight.

George shakes his head, overwhelmed by what he’s being told.

EXT. GOLF CLUB - DAY (MEMORY)

As Kenward's car drives away, Hugo sees Nan and George's headlight is broken in the rearview mirror.

HUGO (V.O.)
The very next morning, who pays me a visit to request my services?

EXT. ALLEY / SIDE GARDEN - MORNING (MEMORY)

Nan speaks to Hugo, who awakens in the alley. As she speaks, he looks at his pocket watch -- 8:00 AM.

HUGO (V.O.)
It was eight in the morning... Now, how could this be possible when the police were not notified until eight thirty that very morning? As noted in the police report.

INT. BALLROOM - DAY (PRESENT)

Hugo paces to the center of the room. Nan fidgets.

HUGO
It was possible because only Mrs. Watts knew that her friend had disappeared.

INT. NAN'S CAR - NIGHT (MEMORY)

Agatha stares forward, eerily still, mind whirring. Nan drives. Nan puts her hand over Agatha's. She doesn't flinch.

INT. BALLROOM - DAY (PRESENT)

Everyone stares, gobsmacked, at Nan.

HUGO
Everything pointed to you... And then I remembered Mrs. Christie’s last novel, the first you gifted me

INT. HUGO APARTMENT - DAY (MEMORY)

Hugo looks at the book -- *THE MURDER OF ROGER ACKROYD*.

HUGO (V.O.)
-- a genius work where the narrator, the writer if you will, the last person we would ever suspect, is actually the mastermind.

INT. BALLROOM - DAY

HUGO
And then every clue fell into place... Nan was not the culprit, she was merely the accomplice.

INT. JEWELRY SHOP - DAY (MEMORY)

Bedraggled yet unnervingly calm, Agatha chooses a ring, and writes down an inscription for the clerk at the counter.

HUGO (V.O.)
Having both the brilliant minds of a detective and a criminal, only Agatha Christie herself could leave clues to either aid or confound us,

EXT. NEWLANDS CORNER - NIGHT (MEMORY)

Agatha pulls her license from her purse and tosses it on the car floor. She pulls the hand brake on, grabs her fur coat and is gone.

HUGO (V.O.)
... even in her most broken state, having experience writer's block for weeks, a plot began to unfold. Mystery somehow bringing order to the chaos...

INT. THE SWAN HOTEL - NIGHT (MEMORY)

On the phone Agatha dictates from a hand written note: "***Maligned seeker of truth, and relative of Teresa Neele...***"

HUGO (V.O.)
She would be found, or she would be lost forever.

INT. OLD SWAN HOTEL - BALLROOM - DAY (PRESENT)

HUGO
The breadbrumbs led me here - but at that point, I fear, our femme fatale had come to the conclusion that maybe she shouldn't be found after all. That it was better for her to disappear completely. So she enlisted her accomplice one last time.

Nan's face reacts upon hearing this new revelation...

EXT. /INT. THE SWAN HOTEL - DAY (MEMORY)

Through a window we see Nan hand a tired looking Agatha a package from a pharmacy. Agatha embraces her.

NAN
Rest. And then you can go and live the rest of your life; take the Orient Express from end to end, make sense of everything.

Agatha looks at her, and hands Nan her fur coat.

AGATHA
Here, I won't need this where I'm going. I love you, dear friend.

Agatha watches as Nan walks away, teary-eyed. Agatha then looks in the package - a bottle of SLEEPING PILLS.

HUGO (V.O.)
She wanted to leave, not in the way her accomplice was led to believe, but with permanence.

INT. OLD SWAN HOTEL - BALLROOM - DAY (PRESENT)

Nan looks on, horrified.

NAN
Oh my god! What have I done?

She cries into her hands, fearing the worst. George comforts her.

Suddenly, the doors open and Inspector Highsmith bursts into the room with a GROUP OF POLICEMEN.

HIGHSMITH
Pieters. Stop this immediately!

HUGO
Great timing, Inspector. I was just wrapping up.

HIGHSMITH
This is a violation of your restraining order. I have no choice but to place you under arrest.

The policemen move forward and take Hugo by each arm.

KENWARD
Sir, let him finish!

As Hugo is being cuffed.

HIGHSMITH
Be quick for God's sake!

HUGO
Agatha Christie, the woman I was hired to find by the very people in this room, *was betrayed by her closest confidantes.* I believe she was so broken, humiliated, and alone that she had to resort to an intricate plan to disappear from a life over which she had lost all control. Has everyone been so blind that they neither saw nor understood their role in this tragedy?

Hugo looks at each person who weighs their guilt and involvement. The tension in the air is palpable as they hang on his every word.

ARCHIE
Get him out of here, I am sick of the sight of him.

Highsmith nods to his men. The policemen start to wrestle him away as Hugo continues.

HUGO
As Agatha herself wrote, and I quote -- "Everyone is a potential murderer..."

SUDDENLY, the door in the back CREAKS OPEN. All heads turn as a shadowed figure from the hall steps into light --

GASPS -- It's Agatha.

AGATHA
... in everyone, there arises from time to time the wish to kill, though not the will to kill."

She slowly moves into the room, expression unreadable. She exchanges glances with Hugo as he shrugs away the policemen.

ARCHIE
Agatha?!

AGATHA
Please uncuff him. If anyone here deserves blame, it's me. You see, Nan sought out Detective Peiters at my request.

HIGHSMITH
(dumbfounded)
Yes... of course.

Agatha composes herself and looks at everyone in the room. She smiles warmly at Hugo.

AGATHA
You have my deepest gratitude, Detective, for finally finding me and reminding me who I am.
(to the room)
I apologize to you all for all the undue pain and distress I may have caused. I wasn't in my right mind.

ARCHIE
(fuming)
Was this some game? Some kind of twisted revenge? Do you know how humiliating this is for me?

Agatha walks up to him with a calm demeanor.

AGATHA
You never asked me the endings to those stories.

ARCHIE
What..?

AGATHA
All the stories I sent you during the war. When you came back, you never asked how they ended. Goodbye, Archie.

She clasps his hand in hers, squeezes it, then walks away. A shell-shocked Archie opens his hand -- her WEDDING RING.

She walks out, leaving Archie and everyone stupefied.

INT. AGATHA'S HOTEL ROOM - BATHROOM - DAY (MEMORY)

In quick cuts: Hugo hoists Agatha's limp body to the bathtub. He slides his fingers down her throat - triggering her gag reflex. Agatha heaves and vomits into the tub.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. HOTEL ROOM - LATER (MEMORY)

Hugo scans the walls of Agatha's hotel room.

It's a chaotic mosaic of scribbled notes and clandestine photos:

Archie laughing, ***The Adulterous Husband***,

Monty staring into space, ***The Tormented Brother***,

Nancy Neale in a crowd of shoppers, ***The Proud Mistress***,

Lane crossing a street, ***The Ruthless Publisher***,

Kenward leaving the Police station, ***The Side Kick***

And at the center of it all: a series of candid photos of Hugo through the years beneath, ***The Detective***,

- Hugo speaks during a press briefing.

- Hugo at the barber. Shaping his handlebar mustache.

- Hugo stands stoic and emotionless at Teresa's grave side.

- Hugo leaves a pub, holding on to the wall.

AGATHA (O.C.)
You've found me.

Hugo turns to see Agatha has woken. He moves to the bedside.

HUGO
I'm only sorry it has taken this long.

Agatha, weak, sits up to face him, and they regard each other for the first time. A wave of relief washes over them both.

AGATHA
I had hoped I would be in a better state when we first met.

HUGO
I don’t believe either of us have been our best of late.

She smiles weakly.

AGATHA
You and I seem to be Master’s at solving others’ mysteries, while masterfully failing with our own.

A silence between them. Hugo pulls out a letter from his coat pocket. He tries to compose himself, as bottled emotions fight to break free.

HUGO
(reading)
To my beloved. I write this letter not knowing if it will ever reach you, but I pray it does if only to know that you are safe from harm...

Hugo can barely continue -- Agatha, knowing the words by heart, continues on his behalf.

AGATHA
I wish only that you were here by my side so that I can help you endure what you must...

EXT. FRANCE - WWI BATTLEFIELD TRENCH - DAY

A miserable rain-soaked day. Hugo, an officer, sits in a muddy trench, trembling from the cold, reading the letter from his wife.

AGATHA (V.O.)
My arms wrapped around you, protecting you from a world that fails to understand you as I do.

INT. HOSPITAL HALLWAY - DAY (MEMORY)

Agatha sits by Teresa, a patient who looks pale and gaunt, too weak to write. We may remember her from the beginning as Nan searches for Agatha. Agatha holds her pen as she reads from the letter she has written.

AGATHA
(in French)
Your last letter brought me great comfort.
(MORE)

AGATHA (CONT'D)
They need those 'little grey cells' of yours on the front line. Your courage helps me face my fears head-on. Know that you are here with me now.

THE CAMERA PANS to reveal that present-day Hugo is indeed there, by her side. Eyes full of tears, looking down at his wife as Agatha reads aloud.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
(in French)
I know that neither time nor place will keep us apart, as we are inseparable. You are my inspiration. You are my life.

TERESA
Parfait.

AGATHA
Wait, we can’t forget our signature farewell, now can we?

Agatha squeezes Teresa's hand and just as she finishes writing, she STOPS. The pen in her hand drops on the ground as she realizes that the life from Teresa’s hand has left.

INT. HOTEL ROOM - DAY (PRESENT)

HUGO
Pour l'éternité.

AGATHA
The sentiment was hers and hers alone. I only put pen to paper. She only thought about keeping you alive.

HUGO
The letters kept me alive.

Hugo places his hand over hers. His touch, electric.

AGATHA
You were lucky to have her.

HUGO
Why me?

AGATHA
You were my detective. You always have been.
(MORE)

AGATHA (CONT'D)
(beat)
When you stopped, I thought perhaps you couldn’t come back on your own. If you found me perhaps we could both step back into being ourselves.

Hugo nods slowly.

AGATHA (CONT'D)
I have been thinking--

HUGO
An admirable exercise.

AGATHA
I have been been thinking far too much in fact. About the things I once loved and how I didn’t want to let them go even though they may have been destroying me. Perhaps it’s time to let them go.

HUGO
Thank you.

AGATHA
I should be the one thanking you. Here you are saving me.

HUGO
It’s quite the contrary I assure you.
(beat)
How does 'Curtain' end?

He coaxes a smile of appreciation from Agatha.

AGATHA
It’s yet to be written.

HUGO
Perhaps it’s time for another muse.

Her expression darkens.

AGATHA
I don’t think I can face them all alone.

HUGO
You won’t have to.

EXT. OLD SWAN HOTEL - DAY

A throng of Reporters, Photographers and Policemen cluster around the steps of The Old Swan Hotel and Spa. It is an ad-hoc press conference. Highsmith stands off to the side with Archie who waits for his turn, fixing his hair.

Hugo steps up to a microphone that has been hastily assembled.

HUGO
Mrs. Agatha Christie has indeed been found in good health and spirits. For eleven days, she has been a guest here at The Swan Hotel. Doctors have ascertained that due to a terrible auto accident, Mrs. Christie suffered a case of amnesia.

Far behind, out of the view of the press, Agatha, in a high-collared coat and hat, walks towards a car where her DRIVER waits.

As the reporters erupt into questions Hugo catches Agatha's gaze over the crowd. He continues.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Having lost her memory, her mind created a fictional life and identity. It was only when we found her and called her by her true name that her memories began to flood back. She is herself again.

Agatha passes Archie's car and sees Rosalind sitting next to a stern-looking NANNY. Agatha places her hand on the window. It takes a few moments for Rosalind to relent, but with tears in her eyes, Rosalind places her hand on the glass, mirroring her mother's hand. The nanny glares at Rosalind, who slowly puts her hand down. Agatha's heart breaks.

REPORTER #1
Detective Pieters, where is Ms. Christie now?

HUGO
I believe she is planning to travel and write.

REPORTER #2
Did she say where?

HUGO
The Orient I believe.

Agatha gets into her car and leaves.

HUGO (CONT'D)
Thank you for your time.

Hugo leaves as more questions erupt and Archie takes the stand.

AT THE BACK OF THE PRESS CONFERENCE

Kenward approaches Hugo with a bag of pastries.

KENWARD
So what now? A return to Scotland Yard?

Hugo reaches for a pastry.

HUGO
I’m not sure the Yard is for me. Too many rules.

KENWARD
I suspect we shall meet again on another investigation.

HUGO
I'd like that.

KENWARD
Maybe I’ll give her novels another try.

HUGO
Do. They’re better than I expected.

INT. STYLES / AGATHA'S OFFICE - DAY

The Housekeeper cleans the office. She dusts the dictaphone with a rag and accidentally hits play. Agatha's voice fills the room...

AGATHA
(dictaphone)
My dear detective. Following your every move and every case. You are not just my muse, but my strength. Without you, I would have never persevered.

WE FLASH TO MOMENTS of Agatha watching and crossing paths with Hugo over the years.

- Getting his haircut at the barber. Shaping his handlebar mustache.

- Passing him at the bar with Hugo apologizing as they brush past each other.

AGATHA (V.O.)
You’ve given me the greatest gift of all. The knowledge that real love, true and pure, exists. Your adoration for Teresa and her understanding of you gives me hope. It is what I want for myself and what I deserve.

- Hugo stands stoic and emotionless during Teresa's funeral.

- Falling and passing out in the alley of his apartment.

AGATHA (V.O.)
We don’t quite belong, you and I. You with your facts, me with my fictions.

EXT. TRAIN STATION - DAY

Agatha walks towards the train, a bright royal blue-hued train pulls into the station with large bold letters painted on the side: THE BLUE TRAIN.

She hands her bags to the porter.

AGATHA (V.O.)
People will always want pieces of you -- they’ll take them, wrap them in their own stories. So keep something for yourself. ALWAYS.

INT. TRAIN - DAY

Agatha takes her seat and looks out the window.

The train engineer calls out for the last boarding.

Out of the corner of her eye, Agatha sees --

Rosalind runs through the crowd.

Agatha puts her hand to the glass, then stands.

AGATHA
Wait... stop the train.

EXT. TRAIN - DAY

Agatha climbs off the train as Rosalind crashes into her arms, sobbing.

Through the rushing passengers, Agatha catches sight of Hugo, and they hold each other's gaze and then, in a swirl of smoke * from the steam engine he is gone.

INT. TRAIN - DAY

Agatha takes her seat alongside Rosalind.

A small, reassured smile forms on her lips.

Just then, a PHOTOGRAPHER snaps a picture of Agatha. Peaceful, unreadable, like the first flash we saw of her. *

SLOWLY the image ages into the true ARCHIVAL PHOTO as we --

FADE TO BLACK.

POSTSCRIPT:

Agatha Christie never discussed her eleven missing days.

She divorced Archie Christie in 1928 and eventually met and married Max Mallowan.

They travelled the world together fueling the research for her best known work.

Her novels have sold roughly 4 BILLION copies worldwide, only third to Shakespeare and the Bible.

Rosalind became the rights holder to her mother' work and fiercely guarded the integrity of every book, play and televised adaptation.

Christie's Hercule Poirot stories remain her most highly regarded to date.

CURTAIN, which featured Poirot's death, was only published by Agatha a few months before she died in 1975. It was written decades earlier.

Some say she just couldn't let him go.